

**FEMINIST VOICE IN AFRICAN WOMEN NOVELS: EVIDENCE FROM FLORA
NWAPA'S ONE IS ENOUGH, CALITXHE BEYALA'S THE SUN HATH LOOKED
UPON ME AND TSITSI DANGAREGMBA'S NERVOUS CONDITIONS**

BY

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Requirements for the award of a Degree of Master of Arts in Literature**

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DECLARATION

I, **Kasonde Angela Kapuka**, do hereby declare that this Thesis is my original work and it has not been presented for a degree in any other University.

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APPROVAL

This dissertation of **Kasonde Angela Kapuka** has been approved as fulfilling the requirements for the award of the degree of Master of Arts in Literature.

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DEDICATION

This is for my mother, Joyce Kabonde Kasonde. For without her, I would not have been...
Her love and sacrifices will always be revered.

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ABSTRACT

The study investigated the feminist voice in African female fiction. It was a feminist appraisal of Nwapa's *One is Enough*, Dangaremba's *Nervous Conditions* and Beyala's *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*. It cross-examines how the authors project the feminist voice(s) in their writing. The research sought to establish whether women can speak for themselves and break free from the grip of patriarchy. The study employed the qualitative method of data collection and several secondary sources that deal specifically with the subject of gender relations and female self-determination were used. Reference was also made to the works of African female writers like Buchi Emecheta, Mariama Bâ and Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie. An analysis of the selected characters from the text was made based on the feminist theory purported by scholars such as Adrienne Rich, Simone de Beauvoir and Kate Millett, to cite just a few. It is this theory that was used to investigate and come up with themes on the feminist voice.

The study was guided by three objectives: (i) To examine how tradition and culture contribute to the oppression of women in the selected texts, (ii) To exemplify that women are ready to break patriarchy ideals in order to liberate themselves and lastly (iii) To analyze the feminist voice in African female fiction. The study is organized in four chapters in line with the set objectives and the stipulated research questions. Chapter One gives a full background of the study highlighting the problem, theoretical foundations and overall concepts of the thesis. Chapter Two reviews the related literature and focuses on the absence of women writers and how they emerged on the literary scenes changing the face of the female. Chapter Three analyses female oppression and reveals how African tradition and culture has contributed to this by prescribing specific gender roles for them. The chapter further explores the female condition in *Nervous Conditions*, sexual violence in *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* and also discusses how marriage and procreation are used as vessels of subjugation in *One is Enough*. The Fourth Chapter explores how the African female writers, through their characters, show that women are able to defy all the odds against them in patriarchal societies. The female writers have given their characters a voice to challenge patriarchal ideologies in this Chapter. This Chapter also exemplifies that women too can make the right choices about their lives, family and children. Chapter five is basically the conclusion to this work.

Keywords: Feminist, Feminism, Patriarchy, Gender, Female Voice, Oppression.

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CHAPTER ONE: GENERAL INTRODUCTION

1.1 Introduction

African women have always been seen as belonging to a weaker sex and it is amazing to note that even in this century, women are still dominated by men. This has been greatly influenced by African tradition and culture. In the early male authored African novels, women were presented as tragic heroines who were unable to speak for themselves. They remained on the periphery and their sole duty was to take care of the home as wives and mothers. This has been exemplified in the literature of the negritude movement such as Senghor and Camara Laye poems in which women are seen solely as mothers. Chinua Achebe also reflected this reality of patriarchy in his works. In *Things Fall Apart* (1958), for example, the man is made the subject of the narrative; he is always the central character while the woman is less fully developed. Women are only classified as mothers and status symbols. The significance of the women and children lies in their dependence on the male character. This male stereotypical representation of women permeated several African male writers' works, although some writers like Sembène Ousmane and Ahmadou Kourouma have portrayed well-rounded female characters.

Shortly after the mid-twentieth century however, African women started writing in an attempt to dismiss male depictions of African womanhood that proliferated the earlier African literature. Flora Nwapa was introduced to the literary circles in 1966 when she wrote her novel *Efuru* and according to Mears (2009: 37), it is then that the reader was introduced to fiction in which women played and had central roles. Therefore, African Women writers became their own mouthpiece, talking about issues that affected them in an attempt to bring about change. In their works, they try to show that they too can make their own choices and participate in their society as fully human beings not just taking up traditional roles as wives and mothers. In the words of Mutunda (2015: 60), "Contemporary female writers have broken the silence and made significant strides in attempting to redefine the role of African women in literature". They have started to present the conditions of the African women in all aspects in an attempt to bring about change. In their works, they try to deconstruct the distorted portrayal of women. They try to restore women to their rightful place either head-on or in a probing manner. Using a feminist language, women writers subvert the masculinity discourse of supremacy and deploy a female-

centered ideology. As Molaria Ogundipe-Leslie (1987), cited in Mutunda (2015: 40) states, “They tell about women and describe reality from the woman’s view point.” Their discourse makes women as protagonists and narrators, it also shows that women too can make their own choices and fully participate in the activities of their communities. In speaking up for themselves, contemporary African women writers delve in daring subjects that are considered taboo in a traditional patriarchal society and which affect women negatively; these include polygamy and sexuality among others. In Flora Nwapa’s *One is Enough*, for example, the author portrays women as being filled with beauty, intelligence and economic power, contrary to what was found in the male authored novels.

Based on selected African women novels, this study looks at the kind of voice that women have in societies that are dominated by men. It will first examine the image of a woman as portrayed in patriarchal societies and then, how she strives to break the barriers of tradition in her quest for freedom.

1.2. Background of the Study

Across the African continent, research and scholarship has shown that before the rise of African women’s writing, African women were subject to negative portrayal and even their contribution was neglected or omitted. The reason being that in the pre-independence Africa, education was the privilege of men. Indeed, as Mutunda (2015: 27) observes, European colonialists privileged the schooling of males. They provided them with the necessary training to carry out the colonial administrative policies. In the meantime, to reinforce the gender difference that were already in place, women were given a training that prepared them to become wives and mothers; this include cookery, sewing and knitting, to cite a few.

In addition, even when colonial schooling became available for girls, traditional norms could not allow them to acquire Western education; parents allotted the boy-child more time to concentrate on his study while burdening the girl-child with domestic chores, for tradition believes that a woman is taken care of by her husband – head and breadwinner of the home. Consequently, when men galloped away, enveloped in education and money driven economy, women were left behind to mind the homes, the children and the farms. European colonialists advantaged the education of males to that of females. They gave them the training they needed in

order to carry out their colonial administrative policies. In the meantime, girls were provided with home oriented education which prepared them to become wives and mothers (Mutunda, 2015: 26). The native men also treated their own women as second class citizens, subservient and sometimes slaves and forced them to study 'womanly subjects' in school. It can therefore be said that colonial policies had strengthened the gender inequality between men and women, and further contributed to the domination of men over women that already existed.

As Mutunda (2015: 26) rightly points out, even when colonial schools became available for girls, traditional norms prevented them from acquiring Western education, thus giving boys more access to Western schooling than girls. In addition, parents gave the boy child more time for study while burdening the girl-child with domestic chores. Juggling between the home, the farm, the books and the market-place, the girl had no time to study and eventually abandoned her education altogether. Mutunda (2015: 27) further submits that, the reason behind such discrimination was the belief that boys were supposed to be breadwinners while girls would be taken care of by their husbands. This is why even the birth of a baby boy was of great importance than that of a girl. Husbands would always anticipate the day that their wives would give birth to a boy. If for example one had ten girls, they would not even be equivalent to one boy. Because men dominate the socio-economic and political organizations of the societies we live in, they are regarded as natural leaders, superior and born to rule over women, while the latter are considered weaker vessels, an extension of men and secondary beings whose dignity is derived from their dependence on men.

In most parts of Africa and in this time and age, women are still treated unfairly. They have to put up with different forms of abuse including physical, mental, sexual, and even verbal. From the time that they are born, women are socialized differently from boys; society expects different attitudes and behaviors from boys and girls. Boys are raised to conform to the male gender role, while girls are raised to conform to the female gender role. Even in the societies where women are regarded as being equal to men, their roles are nevertheless different. Traditionally, women look after their homestead while men find jobs outside the home. In addition, women take care of children, the sick and the elderly, and even all the male folk in the household. This is seen as a sole responsibility of a woman. In her work titled *The Feminist Voice in Contemporary Ghanaian Female Fiction: A Textual Analysis of Amma Darko's*

Faceless and Not Without Flowers, Ofosu (2013) notes that in traditional conjugal division of labour, the bulk of the household chores are allocated to the woman, putting extreme time and energy constraints on the woman, as one female character reveals: “her mind wondered onto the day, which like all days, always began with work and ended with even more work (*Faceless*, 2003: 82). This reflects the amount of work that a woman has to do as she trots from cooking, taking care of the children and has to fulfill her marital duties both at night and during the day. When girls reach puberty and when they are about to get into marriage, they are taught and made to believe that they are just tools for men and are expected to fulfill all the expectations of their husbands. In African tradition, it is believed that a woman can only gain respect after getting married. This is why a woman who is not married has practically no role in society in the view of African tradition. It is expected that all women get married and submit to their husbands. This thought is bound with the idea of child bearing. In his well-researched article, *Portrayal of African Women in Folklore*, Mutunda (2016) observes that,

Marriage is an absolute social must, a sign of maturity and responsibility among the Lunda [for instance]; it is a fulfillment of the wishes and aspirations of one’s parents, extended kin members and society at large. More importantly for women, once in marriage, they are expected by parents and in-laws to bear a child as soon as possible after marriage. (Mutunda, 2016: 516).

In addition, as Mutunda (2016) observes, once a man gets married, his wife should give him as many children as she can, for the more children a man has, the more masculine and virile he is considered by the community. A woman in this situation is not consulted and her opinion does not matter, she is just a mere sexual object that man uses at will because, as the ‘head’ of the family, he is justified to control not only his wife but her womb too. Society equally wants a woman to become a mother as soon as she gets married. This is because a woman is viewed as a nurturer and everyone expects her to take pride in bearing multiple children along with the breast feeding, washing and twenty four hour babysitting. Even so, when a woman fails to bear children, she becomes worthless as child bearing among the Africans is the underlying and basis for every marriage. Mutunda (2016: 516) further asserts that, in most African societies, procreation is so crucial that if a woman appears to be barren, the husband is justified in

marrying a second wife who will be able to bear him children. This implies that the value of a woman lies on her ability to bear children; the more children she bears, the more respected she comes. No matter her status, a childless African woman will experience discomfort and pain and this eventually leads to divorce or polygamy.

According to Juliana Ofori (2013), it is the pain of stereotyping, discrimination and the domestic abuse of females that remains the main worry of many female writers. According to Elia (2007) as quoted by Ofori (2013: 180), husbands and men for that matter have the notion that it is their right to batter women when they think they are falling out of their rules. Thus the act of beating a woman is termed an act of “correction” in the words of Elia (2007). Over time, women have accepted this kind of treatment as this is how they are socialized from the time that they are born. This is because they believe that they have to remain loyal and submissive to their men folk. Some women even consider constant beatings and unnecessary corrections as love.

When the early African male writers began to write, it was this image of African women mentioned above, that they used to portray in their literary works. They presented women as weak and passive expected to be supportive of the menfolk and not be assertive. The male writers seemed to have been influenced chiefly by colonialism and their cultural belief which held a bare respect for the African women by treating them as only subservient. Inspired by their colonizers, Africans male natives treated their women as subordinate adding to their unending plight. They remained on the side lines and were associated with weakness. They were not allowed to participate in important decision making and were, in some cases, not allowed to farm some crops that were considered to be for men as can be seen in Chinua Achebe’s *Things Fall Apart* (1958) and Elechi Amadi’s *The Concubine* (1966). As mentioned earlier, the African first novels were largely written by men. In these works, the presentation of female gender is mostly sloppy and biased, to suit the ideal and interest of male authors. Some of the prominent names around which early African literature evolved include Leopold Senghor, Camara Laye, Chinua Achebe, Elechi Amadi, Ngugi Wa Thiongo and Sembène Ousmane.

In the works of the negritude writers such as that of Senghor and Camara Laye, the female character was the symbol of the earth, the community and of Africa. For example in his poem “Black woman”, Senghor (1976) celebrates the African woman and the landscape she represents: “Nude woman, black woman. Clothed in your color which is life [. . .] And high on

the fiery pass. I find you, Earth promise, in the heart of summer and moon [. . .] And your beauty blasts me full-hearted like the flash of an eagle sun [. . .]" (1976: 33).

In his poem "To my Mother" that introduces his novel *The African Child*, Laye (1955) hails his mother's resignation and patience: "Black woman, woman of Africa, O my mother, I am thinking about you [. . .] O Daman, woman of great simplicity, woman of great resignation, O my mother, I am thinking about you" (Laye, 1955). In this poem, Laye shows the importance of a woman as a nurturer in the African culture.

The early African novels are also filled with male stereotypical representation of women. As Kolawole (1998: 223) rightly points out, male African writers generally present women as a subaltern group in the margin of society, docile and accepting the multiple levels of subjugation gracefully. For instance, in *Things Fall Apart* (1958), Achebe classifies his women as mothers and status symbols; this is because the men were the subject of his narratives and dominated throughout the story. The image of Okonkwo – Achebe's main character – is striking right from the opening of the novel: "He was tall and huge, and his bushy eyebrows and wide nose gave him a very severe look. [. . .] When he walked, his heel hardly touched the ground [. . .] as if he was going to pounce on someone" (Achebe, 1958: 3). This is why his wives, especially the youngest, as well as his children, lived in perpetual fear of his temper. Okonkwo is also shown as courageous man; this is shown from his courageous actions. For example, he beheaded the white man's messenger. Thus, Okonkwo always associated weakness with women; even untitled men of Umuofia were referred to as women.

Women found themselves squeezed in between tradition and cultural philosophies which made them docile and this is what the early male writers tried to show in their works. They portrayed the traditional African society as a man's world where women did not stand a chance nor were they given attention. According to Karik-Namiji (2016), women's roles as wives and mothers restricted their serious involvement in societal affairs and the lack of attainment of these two roles left them totally unfulfilled. In the same way, they were never heard nor accorded a space in literary anthologies. This was a reflection of many African cultures where women were meant to be seen and not heard. The projection of African female characters through the conventional stereotype gave a negative image of women in the works of most male writers like Achebe, Wa Thiongo, Senghor among others. To counteract this stereotyped portrayal, African

women writers attempted to give a positive image of women and began to write. Their commitment to female realistic portrayal shows the vital role of women and the complexities of the African women's own world.

When African women writers emerged on the literary scene, they began to play a prominent role in dispelling male representations of African womanhood that proliferated African literature at the time. Among them are Flora Nwapa, Buchi Emecheta, Bessie Head and Mariama Bâ. These women are challenging patriarchal roles which impede the growth and development of women in their works. As Christian (1985) rightly points out, "the African woman is not content in being a victim, she opts to be an actor in the post-colonial world" (1985: 147). Women started to make their suffering heard by giving fuller accounts of their situation. In their works, they endeavored to depict women abandoned by their husbands, ill-treated by their fathers, disempowered or abused by men, and their reaction to these forces. They raised the voice of women by presenting the conflicts within society with reflection of the aspiration of humanity, for human rights and fundamental freedom.

In short, female writing emerged out of the need for women to speak up for themselves, to have a voice, to counter the idealization and romanticization of the African woman in male-authored works in African literature on one hand, on the other hand, their works are intended to subvert the patriarchal and social-cultural constructs that reduce the African woman to womanhood and wifhood. In other words, women writers strive to bring women to the center from the periphery that they seem to be forced in.

Female writers approach the gender equation in various ways as they attempt to tackle the plight of women and reverse the female marginalization. For instance, the Ghanaian author Ama Ata Aidoo deals with the problems of hypocrisy, corruption and in particular prostitution and the impacts of imperialism in her works like *Something to Talk about on the Way to the Funeral* (1969), *For Things Do Not Change* (1970) and *The Cutting of a Drink* (1970). Aidoo puts the bitter truth of the neocolonialism through her characters; the exploitation of African women by the native black imitating the tradition of the white masters. Buchi Emecheta deals with the women's suffering by setting out to intellectualize and rationalize the trade of flesh and Flora Nwapa is observed to be more concerned to emancipate the women from the restrictive norms of

conduct imposed by the male dominated society. She challenges the traditional portrayal of women in the literature.

1.3. Aim of the Study

My aim in this study is to examine how African female writers, particularly Flora Nwapa, Calixthe Beyala and Tsitsi Dangaremba, in their novels *One is Enough*, *The Sun Hath Looked upon Me*, and *Nervous Conditions* respectively, investigate the struggle of women in patriarchal societies and how they have empowered their female characters in their texts and given them a voice.

1.4. Objectives

My objectives in this study are:

- To examine how culture and tradition, as exemplified in these texts, have contributed to the oppression and subjugation of women.
- To explore how the writers of the selected texts have shown that women have got the power and determination to speak out for themselves, stop male oppression and break the stereotypical and biased ideals practiced in their society.
- To analyze how the female writers have empowered the female characters in their texts and given them a voice.

1.5. Research Questions

This study is underpinned by the following questions:

- How do culture and tradition, as seen in the texts under study, contribute to the oppression of women?
- How do the female characters struggle to defy the odds of their patriarchal societies?
- How have the writers under study given voice to the female characters in their texts?

- To what extent do women in these texts go, in sacrificing for the sake of marriage, family and society?
- How do the choices that the women make give them freedom and what impact do their decisions have on their lives and the society as a whole?

1.6. Statement of the Problem

African women writers often deal with racism, poverty, gender prejudice, ethnic hatred, misrule, famine and misrepresentation. In confronting these social challenges, they have created stories that seek to explore their unique condition. African women writers have spoken for the oppressed groups in theory, in creative works and in politico-ideological commitment. At the moment, there exists numerable literary assessment by scholars, especially the literary critics, on creative works by African writers. The volume “African Literature Today” (ALT) series and other available critical works attest to this. Many books from the stable and many renowned creative writers have been given some level of attention by critics.

Nevertheless, much has not been done, at project level, on The Feminist Voice in Contemporary women novels. This informs the desire to work on this project; hence the need to explore the theme of Feminist Voice in Tsitsi Dangaremba’s *Nervous Conditions*, Calixthe Beyala’s *The Sun Hath Looked upon Me* and Flora Nwapa’s *One is Enough*. This study locates itself in the Feminist discourses, particularly African Feminism, so as to establish how the writers under study highlight the struggle by African women and how they speak for the oppressed group. The central question in this study is: What strategies have women adopted to fight patriarchy as highlighted in the narratives?

1.7. Significance of the Study

A number of literary scholars have looked at the plight of women in patriarchal societies and the subjugation of women by men. This study departs from the conventional image of a woman and showcases her as one who has found or begins to find her voice in a male-dominated world despite the prescribed gender roles. It will reveal that although the rights of women can sometimes be taken for granted, they are able to become independent through education and exposure. Its relevance is that though silence is the assumed virtue for women, it is not always so

and thus the study examines how the selected contemporary women writers have used their female characters to show that they too can be relevant and are able to assert themselves in society even if it means to break the societal norms.

1.8. Theoretical Framework

1.8.1. Feminism and Patriarchy

This study uses the lens of feminism and patriarchy. Feminism is the belief in the social, political, and economic equality of the sexes. It may look at the intersections of sex, gender, nationality and economic status. It focuses on analyzing gender inequality. Feminism began in the Western world in the late 19th century; it became popular in 1968 when a defender of women's rights, Simone de Beauvoir, started writing pieces that explained why it was difficult for talented women to become successful. Themes explored in feminism include discrimination, objectification (especially sexual objectification), oppression, patriarchy, stereotyping, just to name a few. Some of the major tenets of feminism are that despite the biological differences between men and women, they are the same and that sexual stereotyping and social conditions only favor men because they are in leadership positions. Feminism entails the advocacy of women's rights on the grounds of sexual equality. Women are united with a common notion that male domination is oppressive and that there is need for liberation from all forms of women oppression.

Mhindu Admire (2014) in "Can Men Surely Be Feminists? A Feminist Reading of Ngugi's *The River Between* and Achebe's *Anthills of The Savannah*", points out that feminism looks at the distribution of power between males and females, the aim being to create a gender neutral position. It is therefore premised upon the oppression of women and seeks to emancipate them from such oppression. Mhindu (2014: 47) further quotes de Beauvoir as saying that throughout history, women have been reduced to objects for men: 'woman' has been constructed as 'man's other'. Therefore, feminism aims at defining and defending equal political, economic and social rights and equal opportunities for men and women. Although there are various shades of Feminism like American Feminism, African Feminism, French Feminism and so on; all feminists believe that the source of women's oppression is patriarchy.

Commenting on feminism and feminist concern, Mhindu (2014) also notes that feminists claim that women have been stereotyped and it is their concern to expose these stereotypes as well as to do away with them. She cites Bressler (1994) who observes that, women have been stereotyped as angels, demons, saints, whores, brainless housewives or eccentric spinsters. Bressler (1994) argues that these stereotypes should be exposed and challenged because they are evident even in the literary canon. Thus, according to feminists, women must break free from such oppression and define themselves (Bressler, 1994). Feminist critics thus argue that women can only free themselves through challenging the established literary canon that helped shape the images of female inferiority and oppression ingrained in our culture (Bressler, 1994).

According to Mhindu (2014), this therefore implies that, a feminist writer should avoid these stereotypes and elevate the position of women rather than adopting the traditional belief of depicting them as barmaids, prostitutes, old maids or whores. The idea of subordination of women to men is another issue that feminists seek to deconstruct. She further asserts that, feminists believe that it is their duty to expose all forms of oppression so that both sexes are valued as creative, rational beings who can contribute meaningfully to their societies and the world. Hence, a feminist writer should avoid all kinds of subordination of women to men, implying that, the female characters should be given total independence socially, economically, physically, politically and so on. She cites Bressler (1994), who posits that the aim of feminists is to change the world. They want to deconstruct the belief that man is the subject, the one who defines meaning while woman is the object, having her existence defined and determined by the male.

Deeply entrenched in the concept of feminism is the notion of patriarchy. As defined by social scientists such as Weber (1947), patriarchy is “a system of government in which men rule society through their position as head of households” (quoted in Walby, 1990: 19). However, the meaning of the term has evolved since Weber, especially in the writing by radical feminists, who developed the elements of the domination of women by men. For example, Walby (1990) defines patriarchy as “a system of social structures and practices in which men dominate, oppress, and exploit women” (1990: 20). In the same vein, Mutunda (2015) observes that:

Patriarchy is a gender system in which men dominate women. The ascribed superior status of men is encouraged and sustained by

social institutions that are considered unquestionable and natural. In addition, this system of social stratification based on sex provides men with power and material advantages while depriving women of both those benefits (2015: 52).

Radical feminists see patriarchy as the political imperative for physical control over women. They argue that it contributes to the pervasiveness of male domination and maintains their control over women. Women's physical weakness is upheld by patriarchy. Compared to men, they are seen as physically weak. Mhinda (2014: 47) cites Letherby (2003) who observes that, women are considered naturally weak and easy to exploit and as the subordinate sex, women's psychological characteristics imply subordination. Thus, women have been perceived as submissive, passive, docile, dependent, lacking initiative and so on. The nature and social role of women in patriarchal societies is defined in relation to the norm who is the male. They are not viewed as individuals but rather derivatives of their relationship to men. Women are accorded secondary status. Furthermore, Weedon (1987: 2) observes that in patriarchal discourse, the nature and social role of women are defined in relation to a norm which is male. This finds its clearest expression in the generic use of the terms 'man' and 'he' to encompass all of human kind. Therefore, the aim of Feminism is to challenge the privileged position of men and demand that women be viewed as individuals rather than simply derivatives of their relationships to men.

Radical feminists also argue that patriarchy creates the conditions for women to be systematically dominated, exploited and oppressed (Hartman, 1997: 64). The difference between men and women allows men to rule the world and dominate women. Not only does patriarchy prevent women from occupying powerful positions in society but it also creates a negative social view men attach to women. This is why the Radical feminists promote womanhood; they focus on the solidarity and liberation of women regardless of their race and class.

Furthermore, patriarchy is viewed as a social system in which the males hold primary power, predominate in roles of political leadership, social privilege and control of property. In the domain of the family, fathers or father figures hold authority over women and children. The advocates of the concept of patriarchy are often soft Marxists, who argue that underlying the economic class dialectic of Marx is even more fundamental sexual class dialectic though for the most part they emphasize cultural and institutional, rather than economic controls. In addition to

Simone de Beauvoir, this group would include Kate Millett's *Sexual Politics* (1970), Susan Brownmiller *Against Our Will* (1975), Adrienne Rich *Of Woman Born* (1976) and, most importantly, Mary Daly *Beyond God the Father* (1974) and *Gynecology* (1978). The various writers within this school have developed a common theoretical core and have expanded upon each other's ideas. The theorists of patriarchy see males as controlling access to institutional power, and they argue that men mold ideology, philosophy, art, and religion to suit their needs. The exercise of male power is viewed as at least somewhat conspiratorial, and women, whatever their economic status, are perceived as an oppressed class.

Mirkin (1984) in *The Passive Female: The Theory of Patriarchy* cites Adrienne Rich (1976) who argues that, the "power of the fathers has been difficult to grasp because it permeates everything, even the language in which we try to describe it. She states the power of patriarchy is diffuse and concrete; symbolic and literal; universal and expressed with local variations which obscure its universality" (Mirkin, 1984: 42). She further posits that, it does not matter what a woman does, she may "live in purdah or drive a truck, live on kibbutz or be a single parent breadwinner, be the head of state or wash the underwear of a millionaire's wife" (42); regardless of a woman's status or situation, her derived economic class, or her sexual preference, a woman remains under the power of the fathers, and can have access only to so much of privilege or influence as the patriarchy is willing to consent. Further still, Rich (1976) asserts that within patriarchy, men use force, direct pressure, tradition, law and language, customs, education, and the division of labor to define the part that women shall or shall not play. Women are thought of as a subgroup in a man's world. "Patriarchy" is believed to be "equivalent to culture and culture is patriarchy," and the "great" or "liberalizing" periods of history are thought to have been the same for women and men, children and adults (Rich, 1976: 41) .

Assuming the feminist movement, women endeavor on their own forces to tackle the plight of women. The African woman therefore, has a greater struggle against domination and subjugation because of the circumstances that surround her; these include gender, race and culture. Women no longer want to be regarded as weak, inferior or dependent; they want to be accorded some respect. Although the feminist revolutionary movement came in different phases over the years, its focus is the same: the liberation and emancipation of women. As Karik-Namiji (2016) in *Feminism and Intra-Gender Relations in Africa* states, women do not want to assert

their superiority over men; they want to be given equal chance and opportunity to prove themselves as capable. This is why every writer who claims to be feminist should expose and challenge patriarchy in order to create a society which is free of oppression. This is because the oppressor is consciously endeavoring to sustain the oppression indefinitely through patriarchal ideology (Selden, 1989).

Thus, based on the feminist theory, this study explores and analyzes the ways in which literature portrays men and women. It also looks at women's writing and the representation of women's condition within literature. This includes the depiction of fictional female characters. An illustration is made in the study that shows that regardless of the biological differences between men and women, women can be successful in school, community and are able to stand up for themselves and their families. One of the goals of modern feminist literary criticism therefore, is to analyze female fiction and the writings of women from a female perspective and to resist sexism in literature. The study based on feminism shows how women have now stood up to fight for their rights in a patriarchal world.

1.8.2. Feminist Theories

As mentioned earlier, I anchored this research mainly on feminist theory. What exactly is feminism anyway? Scholars and critics have defined feminism in different ways, both as an ideology and a movement. As an ideology, it indicates “the belief and aim that women should have the same rights and opportunities as men” (Hornby, 2010: 545). Similarly, Odonkor and Bampoh-Addo (2014: 123) contend that “feminist ideology preoccupies itself with the liberation of womenfolk from the yoke of masculine domination.” For Amina Mama (2001), “Feminism signals a refusal of oppression, and a commitment to struggling for women's liberation from all forms of oppression – internal, external, psychological and emotional, socio-economic, political and philosophical” (2001: 59). Hooks (2000, cited in Kousouhon et. al. 2015: 315) claims that “feminism is a movement to end sexism, sex exploitation, and oppression.” Drawing on this, sherry Ruth (1988, cited in Olufemi, 2015: 22) defines feminist movement as “a movement concerned with political, social and economic equalities of the sex.” In essence, feminism is about making positive change in the society through the betterment of women. It is worth mentioning that feminism ideology can take different forms; but for the purpose of this research,

I intend to cover four of those types, namely radical feminism, socialist feminism, Marxist feminism, and African feminism.

1.8.2.1. Radical Feminism

Radical feminism is a philosophy emphasizing the patriarchal roots of inequality between men and women. In specific terms, it emphasizes the social dominance of women by men. Radical feminism views patriarchy as dividing rights, privileges and power primarily by gender, and as a result oppressing women and privileging men. Radical feminism's theoretical maxim is patriarchy, or men's pervasive oppression and exploitation of women, which can be found wherever women and men are in contact with each other, in private as well as in public. Radical feminists argue that patriarchy is very hard to eradicate because its root - the belief that women are different and inferior- is deeply embedded in most men's consciousness. Hooks (2000: ix), states that males as a group have and do benefit the most from patriarchy, from the assumption that they are superior to females and should rule over women. On the other hand, she adds that those benefits have come with a price. In return for all the goodies men receive from patriarchy, they are required to dominate women, to exploit and oppress them using violence if they must keep patriarchy intact. Greene and Kahn (1985) also argue:

The oppression of women is both a material reality, originating in material conditions, and a psychological phenomenon, a function of the way women and men perceive one another and themselves. They agree that it is generally true that gender is constructed in patriarchy to serve the interests of male supremacy. Radical feminists argue that the construction of gender is grounded in male attempts to control female sexuality. (1985: 3)

Radical feminism claims that most men have the potential to use physical violence against women, including rape and murder. They point to the commonness of date rape and wife beating, of murders of ex-wives and former girlfriends. According to Lorber (1997:17), the commercial side of this systemic misogyny, or women-hating, is the way women are depicted as sex objects in the mass media and as pieces of meat in pornography, and the global exploitation of girls and young women in prostitution. Even more insidious, they argue that sexual exploitation is the common downside of romantic heterosexual love, which itself is oppressive to women. The threat of violence and rape, radical feminism theorizes, is the way patriarchy

controls all women. When the radical feminists discovered that their individual experiences were not unique to them but widely shared by many women, they came up with ideas of revolution. According to Bryson (2003 cited in Tong, 2009: 48), consciousness-raising showed how:

The trauma of a woman who had been raped or who had had to resort to an illegal abortion seemed to be linked to the experiences of the wife whose husband refused to do his share of housework, appeared never to have heard of the female orgasm or sulked if she went out for the evening; the secretary whose boss insisted that she wear short skirts, expected here to “be nice” to important clients or failed to acknowledge that she was effectively running his office; and the female student whose teachers expected less of the “girls”, refused requests to study female writers or even traded grades for sexual favors.

Endowed by the realization that women’s fates were profoundly linked, radical feminists proclaimed that “the personal is political” and that all women are “sisters.” Radical feminism’s political battlefield has been the protection of rape victims and battered women; as well as condemnation of pornography, prostitution, sexual harassment, and sexual coercion. Since all men derive power from their dominant social status, any sexual relationship between women and men is intrinsically unequal. Kate Millet (1970) as cited by Harris Mirkin (1984: 40) insisted that “the roots of women’s oppressions are buried deep in patriarchy’s sex and gender system.” In her book *Sexual Politics* (1970), she claims that the male-female sex relationship is the paradigm for all power relationships. She further adds that because male control of the public and private worlds maintains patriarchy, male control must be eliminated if women are to be liberated. In the same vein, Lorber (1997: 18) also posits that radical feminism turns male-dominated culture on its head. It takes all the characteristics that are valued in male-dominated societies such as objectivity, distance, control, coolness, aggressiveness, and competitiveness and blames them for wars, poverty, rape, battering, child abuse, and incest. It praises what women do like feed and nurture, cooperate and reciprocate, and attend to bodies, minds, and psyches.

Radical feminism’s criticism of heterosexuality and its valorization of mothering produced a division among feminists, offending many of those who were in heterosexual relationships or who didn’t want children. Its praise of women’s emotionality and nurturing capabilities and condemnation of men’s violent sexuality and aggressiveness has been seen as essentialist, rooted in deep-seated and seemingly intractable differences between two global

categories of people. This concentration on universal gender oppression has led to accusations that radical feminism neglects ethnic and social class differences among men and women, and that it downplays other sources of oppression. According to Mutunda (2016) in *The Portrayal of African Women in Folklore: A case Study of Proverbs among the Lunda in the North-western Part of Zambia* (2016: 515), Radical feminism promotes womanhood rather than aspiring to integrate and assimilate into male-dominated social arena. It is focused upon sexual oppression as a manifestation of women's oppression and social order. Mutunda (2016) further states that radical feminism is premised on the solidarity of women that transcends class, race, and ethnicity. This sisterhood of women is expected to enjoy bonds that are stronger than other existing bonds among men and women (2016: 515). By pitting women against men, radical feminism alienates women of color and working-class women, who feel torn between their feminist and their ethnic and class loyalties (Lorber, 1997: 19).

1.8.2.2. Socialist Feminism

This form of feminism is slightly less extreme but still calls for major social changes. Socialist feminism focuses on both the public and private spheres of a woman's life and argues that the liberation of women can only be achieved by working to end both the cultural and economic sources of women's oppression. The theory expands the Marxist feminists' argument for the role of capitalism in the oppression of women on the one hand, and the radical feminist's theory on the role of gender and patriarchy on the other. Socialist feminists reject the claim that patriarchy is the only or primary source of oppression of women and rather assert that women are unable to be free due to their financial dependence on males in society. They believe that women are subject to male rulers in capitalism due to an uneven balance in wealth and see economic dependence as the driving force of women's subjugation to men. The ubiquity of male control is mirrored in the labour force and career market. Men maintain their control over women by excluding them from some labor and career markets. They do this by occupying positions of power in the labour force, which enable them to dominate in decision-making processes. Hence controlling the labor force gives them power over woman. Millet (1970) depicts this type of control:

Our society is patriarchal. The fact is evident at once if one recalls that military, industry, technology, universities, science, political offices, finances - in short, every avenue of power within the society, including the coercive force of police, is entirely in male hands. (1970: 25)

Socialist feminists see women's liberation as a necessary part of a larger quest for social, economic and political justice. Socialist feminists do not think that the oppression of women is based solely on the economic system, and they suggest that patriarchy and capitalism are combined into one system. In this regard, Mutunda (2016) cites Humm as saying: "social feminists believe that the exploitative economic relations, where the worker is exploited by the dominant capitalist class, could serve as an understanding of gender relations. They further argue that women are second class citizen in patriarchal capitalism which demands for its survival on exploitation of working people and on the social exploitation of women" (2016: 515).

Furthermore, socialist feminists emphasize the economic, social, and cultural importance of women as people who give birth, socialize children, care for the sick, and provide the emotional labour that creates the realm of the home as a retreat for men from the realities of the workplace and the public arena. They see this as important labour that is overlooked and belittled. They are concerned with the reality of what Arlie Hochschild (1989) calls the "second shift." Socialist feminists emphasize that within the workplace women face challenges of job market segregation, lower wages for the same work, and sexual harassment. They also recognize that the labor movement has been complicit in maintaining this. In short, socialist feminism focuses on economics and politics.

1.8.2.3. Marxist Feminism

Marxist Feminism recognizes that women are oppressed, and attributes the oppression to capitalism (Tong, 2009: 96). Thus, insist that the only way to end women's oppression is to overthrow the entire capitalist system.

Marxist feminism focuses on the ways in which women are oppressed through capitalist economic practices and the system of private property. According to this theory, women are exploited in the home and in the work place because much of their labor is uncompensated. One of the important issues in Marxist feminism is the gendered division of labour. It is recognized that there are two types of labour present in a capitalist economic system. These include

productive and reproductive labour. Productive labour refers to work resulting in services and goods that have monetary value within the capitalist economic system. As a result, the producers of these goods and services earn money for their labour. Reproductive labour on the other hand refers to things that people do to take care of themselves rather than for the purpose of earning money. This includes cooking, cleaning and raising children. What Marxist feminism points out is that in capitalist economies, reproductive labour is considered to be exclusively women's labour; this creates a system in which women's labour is separated from men's labour and is considered to be less valuable because it does not earn monetary compensation. Supporters of this theory believe that because women's labour is devalued, women as a group are devalued and oppressed. Marxist feminists further argue that, the source of women's oppression is their economic dependence on a husband and their solution is full-time jobs for women, with the state providing paid maternity leave and child-care (Lorber, 1997: 10).

According to Marx in Marxist concept as cited by Tong (2009: 97), the individual is influenced by the structure of society, which in all modern societies means a class structure; that is, people's opportunities, wants and interests are seen to be shaped by the mode of production that characterizes the society they inhabit. Marxist Feminism theory sees contemporary gender inequality as determined ultimately by the capitalist mode of production. Gender oppression is class oppression and women's subordination is seen as a form of class oppression which is maintained because it serves the interests of capital and the ruling class. Marxist feminists put housewives in the structure of capitalism; this is because of their unpaid work in the home. According to Lorber (1997: 11), Marxist and socialist feminists strongly criticize the family as a source of women's oppression and exploitation. If a woman works for her family in the home, she has to be supported, and so she is economically dependent on the "man of the house," like her children. If she works outside the home, she is still expected to fulfill her domestic duties, and so she ends up working twice as hard as a man, and usually for a lot less pay.

1.8.2.4. Critics of “Western” Feminism

The above types of feminism have been viewed by most African women as too ‘Western’ and they were not relevant to the African context; therefore unsuitable for Africans. Generally, Western thinking has been rejected by many African women and women's groups. They argue

that some traditional values such as the importance of family and children –which Africans hold dear – have not been considered by Western feminist ideology. In this regard, Chukwuma (1994) argues that “African feminism should be understood in the context of the family, where family transcends the nuclear family of husband, wife and biological children. The extended family is the main support base where a woman can always find acceptance and acclaim should her marriage fail. The centrality of the family informs the accommodationist stance of African feminism. Men have a place in it, so do the children” (1994:109). There is also a perception that Western feminism tends to over-focus on male privilege and subordination of women (Oyewumi 2015, cited in Atanga 2013: 303).

1.8.2.5. African Version of Feminism

Generally speaking, African feminism gets to the bottom of African gender relations and the problems of African women - illuminating their causes and consequences - and criticises them. Citing Filomina Chioma Steady, Mekgwe (2008: 16) argued that African feminism emphasizes autonomy and co-operation, nature over culture, the centrality of children, multiple mothering and kinship. Indeed African feminism emphasizes cooperation with men, the affirmation of motherhood and the family; above all, it concerns to criticize patriarchy manifestation in society.

Unlike Western feminism, African feminism is accommodating although some African female writers are radical and at times militant in their approach. Chukwuma (1994) argues that “African feminism should be understood in the context of the family, where family transcends the nuclear family of husband, wife and biological children. The extended family is the main support base where a woman can always find acceptance and acclaim should her marriage fail. The centrality of the family informs the accommodationist stance of African feminism. Men have a place in it, so do the children” (1994:109). African feminism is not antagonistic to men but challenges them to be aware of aspects of women’s subjugation and encourage them to fight such vices. Citing Oyewumi (2005), Atanga (2008) opines that:

African feminism does not focus only on juxtaposing male dominance with female subjugation or on fighting battles with men, nor on fertility rates and poverty, but is also about challenging the status quo, describing the ways in which

contemporary ‘patriarchies’ in Africa constrain women and prevent them from realizing their potential beyond their traditional roles as hard-working income-generating wives and mothers. (2008: 308)

In addition, as Mama (2001) writes, just like other feminisms, African feminism is [not] forgoing all the things that other feminists struggle for – respect, dignity, equality, lives free from violence and the threat of violence. Davies and Graves (1986) summed up African feminism as a political philosophy that:

Recognizes a common struggle with African men for the removal of the yokes of foreign domination and European/American exploitation. It is not antagonistic to African men but challenges them to be aware of certain aspects of women’s subjugation, which differ from the generalized oppression of all African peoples. It recognizes that certain inequalities and limitations existed/exist in traditional societies and that colonialism reinforced them and introduced others. It acknowledges its affinities with international feminism, but delineates a specific African feminism with certain specific needs and goals arising out of the concrete realities of women’s lives in African societies. It examines African societies for institutions which are of value to women [while] reject[ing] those, which work to their detriment, and those not simply import Western women’s agenda. Thus, it respects African women’s status as mother but questions obligatory motherhood and the traditional favoring of sons [. . .] it respects African women’s self-reliance and the penchant to cooperative work and social organization. It understands the interconnectedness of race, class, and sex oppression. (1986: 8-11)

In the above definition, Davies and Graves highlight the compounding effects of colonisation and women’s struggles in Africa. They also acknowledge interaction with Western feminism while simultaneously showcasing African feminism uniqueness. Davies and Graves further show that African feminism is not just about women’s issues, but about intersecting social, cultural, political and economic societal issues that lead to men’s dominance and women’s subjugation.

1.9. Scope of the Study

This study is limited to three novels despite the fact that there is an array of African women writers. This limited corpus was necessitated by the need to have a close analysis of the

selected texts as well as an in-depth look at the struggle of women in patriarchal societies and the ways in which they break the silence imposed on them by society, thereby bringing positive changes to their societies and in their lives.

Limitations of genre have been imposed not only for reason of space allotted, but in the interest of consistency. There are many stories written by all the three writers which might have been included; however, in order to examine an individual work more closely, I have elected to focus on those where the female voice functions as either a central theme or an important backdrop.

1.10. Research Methodology

The basic source of information for this study is the novels. I analyzed selected characters from three primary texts namely *Nervous Conditions*, *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*, and *One is Enough*, based on the feminist and patriarchal theories purported by scholars such as Adrienne Rich, Simone de Beauvoir and Kate Millett. I will support my study with several secondary sources that deal specifically with the subject of gender relations and female self-determination, for instance, reference will be made to the works of African female writers like Buchi Emecheta and Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, to mention just a few.

1.11. Organization of the Thesis

The study is divided into five chapters. Chapter one provides an introduction to the study. It gives a background of the emergence of female writers on the literary landscape. It also gives an insight on the aims, objectives of the study and the theories under which the study is based. The chapter explains the feminist and patriarchal theories and how they apply to the study and ends with the synopsis of the three novels under study.

The Second Chapter provides a literature review on women's participation in literary works and how it has helped to give a true image of the African woman. The Third Chapter discusses gender roles and how they have contributed to making women subservient and subaltern. Chapter Three demonstrates the extent to which women in the texts under consideration have gone in sacrificing for the sake of marriage, family and society. It also illustrates how culture and tradition, as exemplified in these texts and others, have contributed to

the oppression and subjugation of women. The chapter also examines how religion and culture have been used as an excuse to make women subservient in societies that are dominated by men.

Chapter Four displays how the female characters in the selected texts speak out for themselves in order to stop male oppression and break the stereotypical and biased ideals practiced in their society. An exemplification of the fact that women can also think and make appropriate decisions like men will be made. The chapter demonstrates that women today are ready to defy all odds against them and be happy and free. It also gives a textual analysis of *Nervous Conditions*, *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* and *One is Enough*. The chapter further explains the feminist voice in the texts and the choices that the women make in order to find happiness in their lives. It also looks at both the positive and negative effects of the women's choices on their lives and their families. The fifth chapter discusses the finding and concludes this work.

1.12. Definition of Terms

1. **Feminism:** A socio-political movement whose objective is equality of rights, status and power for men and women.
2. **Womanism:** Having or expressing a belief in or respect of women and their talents and abilities beyond the boundaries of race and class.
3. **Patriarchy:** This is a social system in which males hold primary power and predominate in roles of political leadership, moral authority, social privilege and control of property. In the domain of the family, fathers or father figures hold authority over women and children.
4. **Female voice:** A particular opinion or attitude expressed by women.
5. **Subjugation:** To bring under complete control or subjection; to conquer, master or to enslave.
6. **Plight:** A difficult, dangerous or an unfortunate situation that is hard to get out of.
7. **Feminist literary criticism:** This is literary criticism that is informed by the feminist theory. It is concerned with the ways in which literature reinforces or undermines the economic, political, social and psychological oppression of women.
8. **Gender:** This is the state of being male or female.

CHAPTER TWO: LITERATURE REVIEW

There is a significant body of research on women in African literature, and, consequently, a literature review is needed to identify gaps that require further research. This chapter reviews the portrayal of women in African literature broadly.

2.1. Portrayal of Women in Early African Literature

As mentioned earlier, the African first novels were largely written by men. Educated African men who did not only come from patriarchal societies but were educated by colonizers, who also came from patriarchal societies. In their works, the presentation of female gender is mostly sloppy and biased, to suit the ideal and interest of male authors. Some of the prominent names around which early African literature evolved include Leopold Senghor, Camara Laye, Chinua Achebe, Elechi Amadi, Ngugi Wa Thiongo and Sembène Ousmane.

In the works of the negritude writers such as that of Senghor and Camara Laye, the female character was the symbol of the earth, the community and of Africa. For example in his poem “Black woman”, Senghor (1976) celebrates the African woman and the landscape she represents: “Nude woman, black woman. Clothed in your color which is life [. . .] And high on the fiery pass. I find you, Earth promise, in the heart of summer and moon [. . .] And your beauty blasts me full-hearted like the flash of an eagle sun [. . .]” (1976: 33).

In his poem “To my Mother” that introduces his novel *The African Child*, Laye (1955) hails his mother’s resignation and patience: “Black woman, woman of Africa, O my mother, I am thinking about you [. . .] O Daman, woman of great simplicity, woman of great resignation, O my mother, I am thinking about you” (Laye, 1955). In this poem, Laye shows the importance of a woman as a nurturer in the African culture.

The early African novel is also filled with male stereotypical representation of women. As Kolawole (1998: 223) rightly points out, male African writers generally present women as a subaltern group in the margin of society, docile and accepting the multiple levels of subjugation gracefully. For instance, in *Things Fall Apart* (1958), Achebe classifies his women as mothers and status symbols; this is because the men were the subject of his narratives and dominated throughout the story. The image of Okonkwo – Achebe’s main character – is striking right from

the opening of the novel: “He was tall and huge, and his bushy eyebrows and wide nose gave him a very severe look. [. . .] When he walked, his heel hardly touched the ground [. . .] as if he was going to pounce on someone” (Achebe, 1958: 3). This is why his wives, especially the youngest, as well as his children, lived in perpetual fear of his temper. Okonkwo is also shown as a courageous man; this is shown from his courageous actions. For example, he beheaded the white man’s messenger. Thus, Okonkwo always associated weakness with women; even untitled men of Umuofia were referred to as women.

In this patriarchal society; that is where men dominate, Okonkwo’s radicalism is displayed at all levels, even towards his wives and children. We are told, for instance, that he “ruled his household with a heavy hand” (Achebe, 1958: 9), because for him,

No matter how prosperous a man was, if he was unable to rule his women and his children (and especially his women) he was not really a man. He was like the man in the song who had ten and one wives and not enough soup for his foo-foo. (Achebe, 1958: 37)

Rose Acholonu (1994) lends voice to the deplorable condition of Okwonko’s wives in these words: “Okonkwo as a typical tyrant [who] rules and directs his wives in the manner of a cattle herdsman. He roars like ‘the thunder’ and administers physical blows to the wives at the slight provocation. [Okonkwo’s tyrannical life makes] the wives live in awe of him” (Acholonu, 1994: 40).

From the foregoing we can see that Achebe’s male characters are very important individuals. And only men have comfortable room in his narratives. On the other hand, women are lumped together with children as it is generally accepted (in a patriarchal society) the women are second class citizens – to quote Simone de Beauvoir – and are not important creatures who can significantly contribute to nation building. In this novel, the significance of the women and children always depend on the male character and it is clearly illustrated that, a woman’s value evolves only around marriage, the ability to bear children, preferably male children, and work in the kitchen and on small farms.

Elechi Amadi’s *The Concubine* (1970) portrays a society in which the woman’s image conforms to the stiff dictates of patriarchal tradition. The woman of Omokachi village cannot

venture one step outside the social path traced for her. For instance, the central character Ihuona, is a traditional woman who does not venture into men's sphere of life. She is imprisoned into the tradition and customs of Omokachi village. Thus, it is said of her: "[. . .] noted for his traditional, propriety and decorum even love and sex were put in their proper places . . . that was Ihuoma's world and she behaved true to type" (70). She retains the status of a virtuous woman which was bestowed on her by society, because she is aware of being a prisoner of tradition and customs of Omokachi village. Thus, the narrator says of her: "It was as if they were confining her to an ever-narrowing prison" (72). In addition, all attempts at self-expression by women are checked by the overriding interests of the masculine groups and tradition. Thus, when Ihuoma dares to harvest plantains on the disputed piece of land, she is confronted by Madume. The implication of this effrontery is one way of telling Ihuoma not to dare challenge a man – master of the land.

However, not all male writers are biased in their portrayal of female characters in African literature. As Jones (1987: 2) reveals in *Women in African Literature Today*:

While it is true that most male writers have not been able to communicate to us how women feel on the burning issues of polygamy, motherhood and relations between the sexes and have simply presented the traditional picture of the woman...It is not true to say that all male writers have been unsympathetic towards women, or have lacked the ability to present truly complex women, or have merely given us stereotypes.

Jones cites writers like Wole Soyinka, Sembène Ousmane and Ngugi wa Thiongo as outstanding in their depiction of women who are resourceful, determined and resilient and who, when necessary, break through the barriers imposed by tradition on their sex, and take their stand by their men. While in detention and writing *Devil on the cross*, Ngugi (1981), for instance, highlights in his prison diary the importance he accords to his heroine, Jacinta Wariinga by asserting that: "Because the women are the most oppressed and exploited section of the entire working class. I will create a picture of a strong determined woman with a will to resist and to struggle against the conditions of her present being" (1981: 10).

In *God's Bits of Wood* (1960), Sembène's female characters are so crafted as to convey his vision of egalitarian society where women would be seen as partners and not as slaves to

men. The female protagonists in this novel play a major and revolutionary role in the great march from Thiès to Dakar, which was intended to secure fair wages and fringes benefits from the white colonial employers. One of these revolutionary women is Penda; her role in particular is significant because as a prostitute, she understands that making difficult decisions requires freeing oneself from moral and religious constraints. Penda organizes the womenfolk to march from Thiès to Dakar. She conceives the idea of creating a “committee of women” (160) and leads them to the march. Penda, who “from her earliest childhood [. . .] had demonstrated a resolute independence which only increased as she grew up” (136), acts as spokesperson during the strikes. As Godwin Uwah (1993) observes, although Penda dies during the strike, her life offers yet another example of how a cultural stereotype – in this case prostitution – can be transcended, and how conscious escape from myth and the social determinism can elevate an individual. The women in this story contribute to the protest of economic exploitation by supporting their husbands to go on strike. This shows that women in African society are powerful not a weak vessel. They have potentials to bring about positive change in the society.

In Ngugi Wa Thiongo’s *A Grain of Wheat* (1978), the writer also departs from the norm of negative portrayal of women by empowering his female characters through his work. This story describes the Mau - Mau revolutionary movement where Gikuyu men and women fled in the forest to prepare themselves to rid of the British colonizers and the Africans who were supporting the imperialist projects. The women freedom fighters made up five percent of the total movement. Considering that in the Gikuyu traditional society – like most African traditional communities –women had very limited access to decision making, this percentage would be considerable for women to leave their homes and actively and voluntarily take part in the liberation struggle. Citing Itote, Sayed Sadek (2014) observes that some of these women have gone as far as arranging parties “for Government soldiers” and this has “often yield valuable supplies of arms and ammunitions” (2014: 175-176).

Wambui, the major female character in the novel, is a model of resistance. During the Emergency, she carries secrets from the villages to the forest and back to the villages and towns. Once, she carries a pistol “tied to her thighs near the groin” (*Grain*, 19) when she was suddenly stopped in one police check points. When it came to her turn to be searched, she pretended to be an old woman:

[The police officer] started from her chest, rummage under her armpits, gradually working his way down towards the vital spot. And suddenly Wambui screamed, the man stopped, astonished. ‘The children of these days . . . Have lost all your shame? Just because the white man tells you so, you would actually touch your own mother’s [. . .] the woman who gave you birth? All right, I will lift the clothes and you can have a look at your mother, it is so aged and see what it will bring you for the rest of your life.’ She actually made as if to lift her clothes and exposes her nakedness. The man involuntarily turned his eyes away. (*Grain*, 19)

In this story, Ngugi pays respect to the women and celebrates the sacrificial role they played as Mau Mau carriers in the struggle for freedom and the liberation of the homeland. But more importantly, “Wambui’s evasion of colonial strategies of detection is conducted via an ingenious appeal to her revered position as a mother within traditional society” (Nicholls 2000, cited in Sadek 2014: 176-177). Through the depiction of the ideal patriotic women such as Wambui, Ngugi pays tribute to the African women. He believes that though men are fighting openly, the invisible war led by women in fighting for freedom is as much important as that fought by men. In addition, Ngugi wants to demonstrate that if African women had not been such an inner-force, Kenya would never have attained its independence. In this story, female characters are seen to be imbued with more strength and a sense of purpose, traits which distinguish them from their male counterparts.

2.2. Feminist Reaction to Women Portrayal in Early Novels

It is quite obvious that African women have been subjected to negative stereotypes and their contributions have been neglected or omitted. Indeed, as indicated earlier, in the early male-authored novels, women were presented as tragic heroines who were unable to speak for themselves. As a result, feminist critics have denounced the patriarchal bend in these novels, arguing that “women have been cast in marginal roles and depicted as mere objects of sexual gratification, procreation and idle gossips” (Ohale, 2010: 1). This stereotypical depiction of women has prompted feminist scholars and critics such as Helen Chukwuma, Modupe Kolawole, Rose Acholonu, Ogundipe-Leslie, Davies and Graves, and many others, to lend voice to this patriarchal delineation of women in the African first novels. They question the consistent pattern

in these novels in which women have been portrayed as voiceless and in which the action solely revolves around the male. In this regard, Hellen Chukwuma comments that:

The female character in African fiction is a facile lack-lustre human being, the quiet member of a household, content only to bear children, unfulfilled if she does not, and handicapped if she bears only daughters. In the home, she was not part of decision-making both as a daughter, wife and mother even when the decisions affected her directly. (Cited in Ohale, 2010: 1-2)

Similarly, Kolawole (1998: 223), an acclaimed feminist critic and advocate for African women's causes argues that African women are generally presented as a subaltern group in the margin of society, docile and accepting the multiple levels of subjugation gracefully. They are expected to take up roles as care givers and behave in a certain way. This view is also shared by Davies and Graves (1986: 3) when they state that African women's voices have been unheard, thus the images of African woman in pre-colonial as well as in colonial periods were mostly presented by African men who were in charge to write the African literature and through their patriarchal view to tell their female counterparts experience. They further observe that we should bear in mind that "much of this early literature deals with the social and political implications of colonialism and man's struggles within, and away from its confines. According to these scholars, women are usually made peripheral to all of that and function either as symbols or as instruments for the male hero's working out of his problems. In the same breath, Rose Acholonu (1994: 38) contends that men's way of presenting the woman in the literature carried from the folk tradition and that female characters are treated as slaves.

It therefore becomes the burden of the woman to create a parallel character to correct these ills against the woman. In this regard, Mariama Bâ, the acclaimed Senegalese writer and scholar, contends that:

The woman writer has a special mission. She, more than her male counterparts, has to present the condition of the African woman in all its aspects. Injustices persist, segregations continue. [. . .] Discriminations abound in the family, in institutions, in streets,

work places, political assemblies. We must, as women, take charge of our own destiny in order to overthrow the status quo that harms us and we must no longer submit to it. Like men, we must use the non-violent but effective weapon that is literature. (Cited in Mutunda, 2015: 39-40)

For Molaria Ogundipe-Leslie (1987: 5) “the woman writer has two responsibilities: first to tell about being a woman; secondly, to describe reality from a woman’s point of view, a woman’s perspective” (1987: 5). In the same vein, the feminist critic Awa Thiam challenged African women to speak for themselves. In her 1989 book, *Speak Out Black Sisters*, she states:

Black women have been silent for too long. Are they now beginning to find their voices? Is it not high time that they discovered their own voices, that – even if they are unused to speaking for themselves – they now take the floor, if only to say that they exist, that they are human beings – something that is not always immediately obvious – and that, as such they have a right to liberty, respect and dignity. (*Speak Out*, 11)

2.3. Subverting Male Writers’ Representation of Women

In response to the above feminist challenge, African women are increasingly producing a myriad of literary works, to catch up with their male counterparts, fill the void left by years of exclusion from the literary scene and redefine the role of women in African Literature. According to Ohale (2010), the explosion of female writers onto the world stage have been received with excitement because they have dared to challenge the status quo of male domination by redirecting the course of the female character in the African novel. The female writers are determined to entrench feministic sensitivities in the African novel by casting the African female character in a new light and in way hitherto unknown. About this new writing Chukwuma writes:

Feministic writing in Africa today shows the difficult haranguing process of female self-actualisation. This affirmation “I am” presupposes that the subject knows what she is. The whole rubric of feministic literature traces the process of this self-knowledge

and selfhood. This cause is by its nature and goal revolutionary and different and in most cases radical. The cause cuts across the social-cultural norm and in the process sets aside the old ways so as to carve out the new, and must so succeed in the new way that it will attract to itself acclaim, recognition and acceptance. (Cited in Ohale, 2010: 2)

Some of the pioneers of feministic writing include Flora Nwapa, Buchi Emecheta, Nawal Al Saadawi, Mariama Bâ, just to name a few. Rose Acholonu (2003: 133) observes that “These pathfinders [. . .] were empowered by liberal education and the acquisition of liberal skills [. . .] to break the seals of silence and invisibility on the female protagonist by the early traditionalist male writers.” Chukwuma (2004: vii) refers to these female writers as the “New home grown intelligentsia, educated, erudite and probing, fired with the zeal of having a voice and being heard.” Their effort to reverse the stereotypical female image and present a new, assertive and individualistic females have helped to salvage the lope-sided image that male writers have created.

Flora Nwapa’s novel *Efuru* (1966) is a story of a strong, resilient, beautiful and morally upright woman. In the description of this remarkable woman, Nwapa subverts the stereotypical portrayal of woman by most male writers. In this novel, Efuru the protagonist is a woman who loves men; but she maintains her pride as she strives to be financially independent by pursuing her business career. For Efuru, life entails confronting the challenges of living in the world where gender constraints her to live as second class citizen. However, despite the challenges, Efuru is courageous enough to face her problems with success. She is a woman in trade and is well-endowed as a woman physically and intellectually. We are informed by a character: “I heard so much about her [. . .] Her hands make money. Anything she touches is money. If she begins to sell pepper in the market, she will make money out of it. If in salt, money will flow in” (156).

Education is obviously and has remained the most effective tool for African women’s empowerment and has thus, sustained and helped them to rise to the occasion in moments of crises. It has made women aware of the many choices available to them and to know that they should not just fold their arms and wallow in despair, but they should think, plan and act

whenever an opportunity avails to them. Charles Nnolim in his discussion of Nwapa's women's characters actually writes; "The lesson? Women shall never stop suffering at the hands of men. But the women's saving grace, their last redoubt, lies in being economically independent (2000: 113). A best example of this strategy is found in Buchi Emecheta's *Second Class Citizen* (1974) where Adah the protagonist tactfully decides to bring her dream to fruition by joining her husband in England for studies, a strategy that works out just well.

In the novel, Adah, an intelligent, ambitious young girl who has to fight against different odds to gain an education in Lagos. As a child, she has to inject herself into the classroom of a friendly neighbouring teacher before she was even enrolled in school. This can be explained by the fact that her parents (especially her mother) have doubts the idea of sending girls to school. When her father died, she moved into a relative's home who, unfortunately kept her like a slave. After a life of misery and exploitation, coupled with self-motivation, Adah wins a scholarship to a highly competitive secondary school. As a result of exceptional performance, the protagonist is able to secure a job at the American consulate in Lagos – a job that brings her a comfortable life. During the same period, she meets Francis Obi, a young account student whom she agrees to marry. With his parents' approval, Francis decides to go for further studies in Britain. This idea is accepted by Adah because; in part, it provides an avenue for her to fulfil her own dreams of going in Britain to pursue her education. When she finally joins her husband in Britain, she discovers that her childhood vision of it was as a result of the cultural domination of the colonizers. This is because she is discriminated against by the whites because she is black and by her own community because she does not comply with the prescribed gender roles. The husband on the other hand firmly believes that a woman's place is in the home however, she refuses to be harassed by him and rises above her unhappy marriage and struggles to pursue her dream of becoming a writer.

According to Zahri Barfi et. al. (2015: 36), Emecheta depicts African women who are marginalized by various forms of oppression preventing them to attain self-realization. They further suggest that Emecheta through her writing gives a self-understanding to African women. In other words, she attempts to reform the quality of African women's lives. This view is also voiced by (Parekh & Jagne, 1988:150) as cited by Zahri Barfi et al (2015) who are of the view that Emecheta tries to speak for Igbo [and African] women and calls for "political consciousness

of all women, couples with questioning and challenging the marginalization of women in all social systems". This then proves Karik's (2016: 16) view that women through their writing create awareness of women about the difficulties that women face in a male dominated society. According to Karik female writing has awoken the desire in women to achieve self-fulfillment outside of the roles forced upon them by the society. She mentions Elaine Showalter (1985) as successfully contributing in shifting the focus of attention from 'woman as reader' to 'woman as writer'. Karik voices that this is an attempt to give the woman a voice and a platform to express herself and the experiences of other women from a feminine perspective. This is equally an opportunity for the woman to correct the stereotypical image of the woman as expressed by the male authors.

Nawal El-Saadawi's *Woman at Point Zero* (1986) also points out that women are always disadvantaged in any relationship with the opposite sex. She shows the image of the woman as a sex object in the hands of men in society. In this novel, the author brings to fore the various stages of injustice and abuse that the protagonist Firdaus grapples with in a phallocentric society. In her early years at her parental home, Firdaus is mistreated by her father like a slave; she sometimes goes to bed on an empty stomach while her father never spends a night without food. Thereafter, she goes to live with her uncle in the city in the hope that she will pursue her studies and become independent, but her uncle decides to marry her off – against her will – to an old rich widower named Sheik Mahmoud. The latter subjects her to inhumane treatment that does not fit a wife. For example, her sexual relationship with her old husband is a torment: "Sheik Mahmoud had a hollowed swelling on one chin that discharged some pus and Firdaus was forced to kiss him despite the stench of dead dogs emanating from it" (*Woman at Point Zero*, 43). Besides, she undergoes unnecessary and unjustified physical violence.

After enduring marital rape and repeated beatings, the protagonist ends up in a coffee shop where she meets Bayouni, the shop owner who, like the early man, beats her and even locks her in the room when he leaves. Eventually, she escapes from Bayouni's brutality and goes into the street where she meets Sharifa El Dine, a professional prostitute who takes her in and teaches her to become a high-class prostitute. By using her body as source of revenue, Firdaus slowly attains her freedom: "Now I can decide on the food I wanted to eat, the house I preferred to live in" (*Woman at Point Zero*, 68), she says. Soon, Firdaus realizes that her benefactor is just an

exploiter who wants to take advantage of her innocence and vulnerability, which prompts her to leave. Soon after, she finds a job as a secretary in a local firm. As Mutunda (2016) observes, “By leaving the world of prostitution to join the corporate world, Firdaus thinks that this move will provide her the respectability she needs and deserves” (2016: 719). Unfortunately, she comes to the realisation that as long as she is a woman living in a phallocentric society, she cannot run away from the gaze of men who want to use her as an object of sexual gratification. Thus, she meets Ibrahim, a workmate with whom she develops an intimate relationship that she hopes and believes would lead to marriage. Unfortunately, Ibrahim gallops away and marries the daughter of his boss, leaving Firdaus hurt and devastated.

In desperation, Firdaus goes back to prostitution, determined to be a master of her own destiny. She prefers her trade because it gives her freedom and power over men: “I prefer to be a free prostitute, rather than an enslaved wife” (91), she says. However, she realizes that even here, she does not have the peace and freedom she longs for. She has to contend with Marzook, a violent pimp who wants to exploit and rule her. Faced with this quagmire, she has no option but to defend herself. So, she decides to kill the abusive and exploitative Marzook. While some may read this murder as a criminal act, for which Firdaus is finally imprisoned. I agree with Mutunda (2016) who contends: “The killing is a symbolic act that would avenge women from the yoke of patriarchy they have been saddled with” (2016: 720). In the same breath, Assah (2003) points out that “the killing seeks to destroy [man] the phallic symbol, source of oppression and violence [against women]” (532). I should also add that the act of Killing is a way El-Saadawi uses to empowering a gender that is kept subjugated in her society: “Voiceless and powerless at the beginning of the story, Firdaus reaches her self-realisation in the end” (Mutunda, 2016: 720). El Sadaawi has created a female character that is able to speak out. The importance of creating such a character is echoed by Ezeigbo (1990: 149), who argues on the need for the female writers to show and create authentic and realistic female characters that would provide their female readers with satisfactory role models. Karik (2016: 21) also opines that women’s writings should be revolutionary and in some cases radical, but the common focus is giving the woman a voice to demand for her rights.

Mariama Bâ's *So Long a Letter* (1981) portrays the fate of women in traditional marriage as that of oppression; she poses the problem of polygamy and its destructive effects on women. In the novel, the author presents Aïssatou, a mother of four sons, expressing her disappointment at her husband's decision to marry another wife after years of a happy marriage. As soon as Aïssatou's husband Mawdo, takes his cousin Nabou as a second wife, she walks out of her marriage, taking away her sons while leaving this letter for Mawdo, which reads in part:

[. . .] I cannot accept what you are offering me today in place of happiness we once had. You want to draw a line between heartfelt love and physical love. I say that there can be no union of bodies without the heart's acceptance, however little that may be. [. . .] I am stripping myself of your love, your name. Clothed in my dignity, the only garment, I go away. (31-32)

Here we are presented with a courageous woman whose determination and sense of purpose propels her to control her destiny. Many feminist critics have praised Aïssatou for her courageous stance. For instance, Julie Agbasiere (1999) views Aïssatou as a woman of action who is ruled by her head, who knows what she wants and goes for it" (cited in Mutunda, 2015: 42). For Helen Chukwuma, Aïssatou is courageous enough "to burst the fence of subjugation and nihilism and turns her back to its oppression" (cited in Mutunda, 2015: 42).

By her single act, Aïssatou confronts the shackles of subjugation and sets herself free, unlike her friend Ramatoulaye who broods over her husband's betrayal and eventual death. Certainly, Bâ supports the idea that a woman should not remain in a marriage under suffocating circumstances, absorbing humiliation after humiliation, until she is completely destroyed. She affirms that "Marriage is no chain. It is a mutual agreement over a life's program." She also wonders "if one partner is no longer satisfied with the union, why should he remain?" (74). In her paper *Women's Quest For Rights: African Feminist Theory in Fiction* (2006), Chukwuma posits that women writers make their female protagonists burst the marriage institution when it becomes too subjugating. She gives examples of Amaka in *One is Enough*, Firdaus in *Woman at Point Zero*, Aïssatou in *So Long a Letter*, Adah in *Second Class Citizen*, Adaku in *Joys of Motherhood* and others, who go away from their matrimonial homes, distancing themselves physically and psychologically to seek their individuality and self-realization in the wider world.

This view by Chukwuma is also buttressed by Frank (1987: 15) who suggests that: "...women must spurn patriarchy in all its guises and create a safe, sane, supportive world of women: a world of mothers and daughters, sisters, and friends." According to Karik (2016: 22), this is a call to break down all barriers existing within the camp of womenfolk so as to join hands together to push forward and achieve the feminist aspirations.

African women writers have redefined the meaning of feminism; this is because they have exposed the restrictions that are imposed on women by traditional African societies through their writing. They also disapprove of patriarchy and its oppressive nature. According to Mutunda (2015: 68), by taking up the pen, women writers have defined themselves in their own terms. By moving their female protagonists from the periphery to the center, African female writers have empowered their women and made them assertive. Mutunda (2015: 64), further states that as women writers strive to correct the erroneous image of women, they have distinguished themselves by presenting new forms of writing. He gives an example of Calixthe Beyala who directly attacks patriarchy and the society. Just as the powerful use language to 'oppress and silence their subordinates' (Cameron 1992:1), Beyala, in her novel, *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*, uses feminist language to subvert the masculinist discourse of supremacy and deploys a female-centered ideology. Her discourse makes women visible as protagonists and narrators with strong female agency and visibility at the same time as it attempts to subvert the crude male hegemony, not by elevating women, but by illustrating how masculinist attitude of her male characters degrade the men themselves as surely as the men degrade women (Mutunda, 2015: 64). Ogundipe-Leslie (1987: 8) also postulates that by expressing their own experiences, and illustrating how to deal with diverse issues affecting them, African women writers reflect the "the reality of the African woman." Chukwuma is also of the opinion that one of the ways in which women writers can liberate their women characters from the gendered yoke was to make them burst the system and be free. By the time the shock waves subside, the lesson would have been learnt (2006: 5). She further opines that women should break out of subsuming norms and situations as the marriage institution, even though they stand a chance of being dubbed cultural deviationists.

Mhindu (2014: 45) also affirms that a feminist writer should avoid all kinds of subordination of women to men, implying that, the female characters should be given total independence socially, economically, physically, politically and so on. This is because it is the feminist's sole duty to expose all forms of oppression so that both sexes are valued as creative, rational beings who can contribute meaningfully to their societies and the world. Karik-Namiji, Olubukola in *Feminism and Intra-Gender Relations in Africa: A Theoretical and Conceptual Framework* (2016:15) is also of the idea that feminism and its criticism can only be a success if women are bodacious enough to write about women and recreate the image of women through their development of strong female characters who will correct the portrayal of women in texts written by men. To stress the need for women to have a voice, Karik (2016) further cites Cixous in (Gunew, 226) who concludes that women should break out of the snare of silence and passivity by "writing, from and towards women and by taking up the challenge of speech which has been governed by the phallus." Rosalind Jones (1985) as cited by Moyana Rosemary (1994: 31) also adds her voice when she states that writing is one of the sites of liberation in this phallocentric world. She further argues that if women have been entrapped in the symbolic order, they will mark their escape from it by producing texts that challenge and move beyond the law-of-the Father.

CHAPTER THREE

3.1. Synopsis of Novels

Tsitsi Dangaremba's *Nervous Conditions* (1988) focuses on Tambu, the main character of the story. The novel examines unequal power relations between men and women. The story opens with the news that Tambu's elder brother Nhamo had died. Tambu is not upset with this news because Nhamo had always made fun of her that she would not amount to anything in life because she was a girl. Nhamo studied at a missionary school away from his homestead and lived with his uncle Babamukuru and his family. The only thing that Tambu desires is to attend school; however, her family is very poor and does not have money to pay for her school fees. Because she is a girl, her father does not pay attention to her education. After the death of Nhamo, Babamukuru suggests that Tambu should take her brother's place and attend the missionary school. When she arrives at her uncle's home, she completely focuses on her studies. The emotional distance that existed between her and her cousin Nyasha soon disappears, she learns the rhythms of the household and also witnesses the frequent fights between Nyasha and Babamukuru. Tambu also learns that Maiguru is highly educated while living in Babamukuru's home; even so, her financial contributions in the house are not recognized. Towards the end of the term, she excels in the exam and is offered a scholarship to attend a prestigious missionary school. She is introduced to many cultural changes but she remains resistant to these changes as she is focused on her studies.

Calixthe Beyala's *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* (1996) is her first novel. It concerns the struggles of Ateba Leocadie, a young woman in the Quartier General (GQ), an African shanty-town of Awu. Ateba is a daughter of an unknown father and a prostitute mother. Abandoned by her mother, she is raised by her aunt Ada who mistreats her even though Ateba takes care of her needs. She makes a living by selling her body and we learn that she lives in a community where women suffer a lot of violence. Her life is shaken when Jean Zepp forces a relationship on her. She seeks to end the tyranny of men because she holds them responsible for the death of an old neighborhood prostitute and her friend Irene, who dies from a botched abortion.

In Flora Nwapa's *One is Enough* (1966), the author tells the story of how the protagonist Amaka, struggles to lead a life of her own. After many years of living alone, Amaka gets married to Obiora. After six years of marriage without children, Amaka discovers that her husband plans to marry another woman who has already borne him two children in secrecy. In the text, Amaka is detested by her in-laws because she is unable to produce offspring. Her doctors had declared her barren, while her mother in law forced her to flee her matrimonial home. She refuses to stay with her adulterous husband and goes to Lagos in search of a new life. In Lagos, she is involved with a number of men who helped her with important contracts from the government. To become a successful businesswoman, she gets involved in two romantic relationships with a businessman named Alhaji, and a Catholic Priest (Izu) for whom she bears twin children. When the priest declares his wish to marry her, Amaka rejects his proposal stating that she does not want to be a wife anymore. Amaka's relationship with Alhaji is based exclusively on business – helping her to receive contracts – and there are no feelings between them. At the end of the novel, Amaka becomes a famous businesswoman and a mother. She follows her mother's advice which was to forget men, live an independent life and have her own children.

3.2. Cultures Influence on Women's Oppression: A Woman Perspective

3.2.1 The Female Condition in Nervous Conditions

Africa has diverse cultures which have different notions about the male and female roles. Regardless of this; women have been subordinate to men in both family and public life. Tsitsi Dangaremba in her *Nervous Conditions* (1988) shows the gender roles, notions about sex and standards of sexual behaviour among the Shona people of Zimbabwe. Traditional cultures, such as the one portrayed in the novel *Nervous Conditions*, form distinct roles for men and women. In this novel, the father or oldest male in the home is recognised as the only decision maker in the culture of the Shona and the novel clearly demonstrates the acceptance that male dominance is a natural part of life in rural African communities. In the novel, Dangaremba exemplifies how patriarchy has penetrated the African culture and has become the norm. She demonstrates how women's general acceptance of demotion is perpetuated by men who defend their superiority as culturally important. This point is clearly illustrated by Dangaremba: as her protagonist, Tambu, is denied access to equal education because she is female. Her father's refusal to allow

her to attend school is fuelled by cultural assumptions which consider education as a male privilege. Her supposed place is at home, catering for her family and later for her husband and children.

This cultural pattern in the Sigauke clan proves The United Nations Economic and Social councils' 1963 report on Urban Problems: *The Role of Women in Urban Development*, that there is a specific place that is given to each member of an African family. This is because the family confers on each member specific duties and privileges. The African culture confers certain specific rights on boys and girls. Each sex group is expected to behave in a certain way. Boys for example are taught and expected to be manly while girls are socialized in a way that they get prepared to be future wives and mothers (UNECA Workshop 1963/07). This is why Tambu's hardships as the oldest girl in her family could be traced from infancy; she had to cultivate the fields, fetch water from Nyamarira River, look after her younger siblings, cook for the family, and sleep on the kitchen floor on cold days with a single, threadbare blanket as cover. Traditionally, African women were taught how to be teachers to their children and better housekeepers. They would receive careful instructions regarding the beauty of girlhood as shown by modesty, unselfishness, and by unostentatious care for others.

Despite all this, Tambu also had to endure humiliation from her brother, Nhamo, who made her an object of mockery. When she decides to seek solidarity from Nhamo, he could not help because he was going to school: "Why do you bother?" He asked, his eyes twinkling maliciously. "Don't you know that I am the one who has to go to school?" (20). Later on when Tambu decides to plant mealies (maize) and sell them to pay for her school, Nhamo steals them and gives them out to his friends and he is not even ashamed to fight his sister. He does this because he does not want his sister to be at the same level as him. This element of male chauvinism can already be seen even in this young boy because of the socialisation process and the traditional African culture. Nhamo clearly tells her: "Did you ever hear a girl being taken away to school? You were even lucky to go back to Rutivi. With me, it's different. I was meant to be educated" (1988:49). These sentiments expressed by Nhamo visibly express the fact that a woman's place has traditionally been inferior to that of her male counterpart. Whatever is considered most valuable in society is placed under the direction of men and whatever is considered less valuable is given to women to care for.

Tambuzai's mother Mainini had accepted this reality and this is why she views her daughter's feeble efforts in trying to educate herself as ridiculous. Since she was a girl, her mother Mainini tried to teach her how to tolerate hardships as a woman. She had a preconception that that was the life of a woman. She knew that in her society, women played their significant roles as mothers, and in this position they bore and taught children, were loyal and loving to their families and in many cases subordinated themselves in the service of their husbands, children, families and clans. Without any sense of her own self-determination, she was unable to think of an identity for her daughter outside of marriage. Economic powerlessness and 19 years of domestic labour had taught Mainini how to survive what she could not change. She has been socialized into assuming an unreceptive role in an environment dominated by patriarchy. It is this role of resignation that she expected her girls to emulate. She advises her daughter: "This business of womanhood is a heavy burden . . . what will help you my child is to learn to carry your burden with strength" (1988: 16). She does not encourage her daughter to study as she feels that every woman was doomed to live life under the domination of the fathers. Through the eyes of Mainini, one can see that Women are seen as perfect administrators of the household who pass on social values to their children. Butengwa (1993) validates this tendency when she refers to the African culture by arguing that a closer analysis of this 'culture' would expose that "only those aspects of culture which uphold the subordination of women are considered as culture" (1993: 27). According to tradition, it is generally presumed that women will always be maintained by males, be it a brother, uncle, father or husband. Butengwa (1993) further asserts that a woman is regarded as a legal minor, from birth to death (1993: 28). This is indicative of the oppressive nature of cultural norms, which perpetuate women's relegation to inferior position.

Dangaremba in this work demonstrates the universality of patriarchy and the role of women in this culture, Tambu is culturally restricted to roles that deny her opportunity to rise above domesticity; her brother Nhamo, on the other hand, is able to study. He is privileged to attend school with the whites who were part of the ruling colonial class. Furthermore, Nhamo was able to attend school despite the family having to strive to earn a living. This was consonant with the patriarchal beliefs of empowering male members of the family for perpetual domination. Mainini is aware that investing in education would safeguard her family from poverty however, it is her son and not her daughter whom she foresees would become a provider for the family, if

he were to be given an education. She struggles to ensure that Nhamo receives an education. When there were no funds for children's schooling, she planted vegetables and sold them at the bus rank. With the extra cash, she paid for Nhamo's education but not for Tambu's. This is because Mainini had the mindset that promoted male domination. According to Creamer (1994:352) she believed that the education for the son would achieve familiar expectations whereas the gains of a daughter would be certainly lost to her husband's family.

Similarly in *The Joys of Motherhood* (1979) by Buchi Emecheta, Nnu Ego and her husband Nnaife give up everything so that their eldest son Oshia can get educated. The left over money if any would go to educate their second son Adim. There was never any thought of giving their daughters an education. This is because daughters were looked at as an investment. Hopefully, they would marry and bring in the good bride-price which would likely also go to their brothers' education. Nnu Ego assumes that her sons will come home and take care of her after she ages. Nnu realised that part of the pride of motherhood was to look a little unfashionable and be able to drawl with joy; "I can't afford another outfit, because I am nursing him, so you see I can't go anywhere to sell anything". One usually received the answer "never mind, he will grow up and clothe you and farm for you, so that your old age will be sweet" (Emecheta, 1979: 80). It can be noted that although *Nervous Conditions* takes place in a different area of the African continent, it reflects the same values of gender education. It is after Nhamo dies that the family decides to take Tambu to school because they were no male children.

It can therefore be said that the boy child in African societies is honoured more than the girl. In *Nervous Conditions*, Nhamo was more privileged than his sister Tambu because of his gender. While he went to school, she had to be content with being groomed as a prospective bride. Nhamo, despite being privileged tried by all means to bring her down, as when he stole her maize and gave it to friends, and to dominate over her as a male. He constantly reminded her that she could not amount to anything because she was a girl. This mindset is further upheld by Tambu's father, Jeremiah, when he asked her whether it was possible to "cook books and feed them to your husband? Stay at home with your mother. Learn to cook and clean. Grow vegetables" (1988: 15). These remarks by her father describe the exact place of a woman in this society. During the holidays when her uncle Babamukuru had his family come to visit, there were "twenty-four stomachs to fill three times a day. Twenty four bodies to which water had to

be fetched from Nyamora daily. Twenty-four people's laundry to wash as often as possible . . . Now, this was women's work." (Dangaremba, 1988:133). Mutunda (2015: 46) is of the view that parents were generally reluctant to send their daughters to school because the types of employment formal education could provide were mainly reserved for men. He further states that even the little education women received was faced with resistance from families on grounds that they would refuse to marry or, once married, would resist submission to men as required by patriarchy.

The novel's protagonist, Tambu, is denied access to education because she is a girl. Her father's refusal to further her education is influenced by cultural conventions, which consider education to be a male domain. Jeremiah did not even want his daughter to be over-absorbed in intellectual pursuits. He often felt agitated when he found Tambu reading the sheet of Newspaper in which the bread from magrosa had been wrapped. Jeremiah thought that Tambu was emulating her brother and that the things she read would fill her mind with impractical ideas, making her quite useless for the real tasks of feminine living (1988: 34). There is a belief in the text that once a girl comes of age, she has to be married off. This makes one realize how much marriage to a man is important in the Shona society in particular and African culture in general. It can be interpreted that women have also complied to being treated as objects that have a worth to be bought and sold like a fruit on a stall, showing that women are also inferior.

Tambu's proper place is assumed to be in the home, serving her family and, later, her husband. From the reading of Dangaremba's novel, it can be concluded that women in the Shona culture are taken as perfect managers of the household who pass on societal values to their children. Even after she is taken to school, the family still discuss how worthless her education was as she would eventually be helping her husband's family and not her own. This is reflected in the novel through the experiences women have as they fight for independence and equality. Although others may argue otherwise, these things are still being practiced in some parts of the world. Adeola James (1990) goes on to suggest that, "The real reason for the tragic disruption of society depicted in *Things Fall Apart* (1958) by Achebe is because the female principle is neglected whilst the male principle, with its strong headedness and inflexibility, is promoted above all else" (James, 1990: 42). In the novel, the unfairness regarding education in Africa is

brought to light. The stereotypical and biased ideals as practiced in this society can be seen to intrinsically contribute to the oppression of women.

In African societies, the oldest male is usually the decision maker for the family and women are expected to remain silent on any key matters and this is what we see in *Nervous Conditions* where Babamukuru has the ultimate authority. Dangarembga's portrayal of women's powerlessness is exemplified through Maiguru's remarks to Tambu about her dislike for her husband's careless spending habits; she begrudges her husband (Babamukuru) for supporting his bothersome family with her wages. However, her role as a wife forbids her to speak out against him. Mama in Adichie's *Purple Hibiscus* also suffers such suppressing internment. She has no voice and does not talk to Papa; she is a dehumanized wife and suffers in solitary. It can be argued that patriarchy has always tried to control the domestic space and deny women the chance to enter into the public sphere and these women are a symbol of oppressed African women. The patriarchs seem to mold tradition and religion in order to suit themselves.

Men in Africa are seen as supreme and this is revealed in the novel as Babamukuru is respected by all the members of his family, his authority over all women within the clan portrays how patriarchy creates the conditions for women to be dominated, exploited and oppressed. This model image appreciated by Tambu towards Babamukuru was reinforced by the clan's gratitude when Babamukuru had found a job for Lucia. When Babamukuru said, "Not much. A little job, at the girl's hostel. You will help to cook food there at the hostel" (1988: 158). This statement was received with joy and ululations. Lucia's response was to cite Babamukuru's ancestry. These praises are the highest that can be bestowed on somebody within the African context. Of course, Lucia was on her knees when she praised him. Tambu's mother performed a similar gesture, by kneeling and worshipping beside Lucia. Maiguru completed the picture by also kneeling on the floor despite her status accorded to her education. Tambu's admiration for Babamukuru was so great that she regarded him "as the closest thing a human being could get to God" (1988: 199). This level of male supremacy is also reflected in Chimamanda Ngozi's *Purple Hibiscus* (2003). We also learn from the text of the disturbing sounds of male domination as Kambili narrates that in her household, it was papa who had the supremacy over mama. From the novel, we see the traditionalist father who has a mischief to his words and states that women

are not important with a slight bit of sarcasm. The thought by mama that man is essential and the centre of the family also clearly shows the traditional and the catholic view of men.

Maiguru and Mainini both pay the highest price for being female partners in their household. Regardless of the high standard of education that Maiguru had acquired overseas, she is subjected to the same treatment as that of the uneducated women. For example in the company of her in-laws, she sat on the floor, as is customary for women, as patriarchy is unchallengeable according to tradition. No matter how discomforting an instruction could be from her husband, she complied without questioning or grumbling. Maiguru does not even have equal control over the management and allocation of the family income. Babamukuru had entire control of her income by virtue of being the family head. In African societies the father is the ultimate decision-maker for the family and women are expected to remain docile. Women's enslavement is portrayed in Dangaremba's *Nervous Conditions*, this is evidenced in Maiguru remarks to Tambu about her dissatisfaction with the manner in which her husband handles household finances. She resents her husband's lavish support of his brother's family partly from her wages. Conversely, her position as a wife prohibits her to act against her husband's will. Although she did express misgivings during one Christmas vacation when too much meat was purchased for the clan, as Babamukuru's wife, her own potential and aspirations are completely submerged in the role of wife and mother prescribed by Shona patriarchy. And, as the wife of the mission school headmaster, her submission is strengthened by the Christian ideal of the dutiful and obedient partner. Maiguru covers her deep seated bitterness and frustration brought about by her husband's control of her life.

The discrimination between the male and female can be traced from the early stages of a girl's life during the process of socialisation. From the time that boys are young, they are given challenging tasks the girls on the other hand have to bear their future role as a wife, housekeeper, mother and this is marked into her future with little chance of change. These gender roles are deeply rooted within societal customs which would take many years to change. This is evident in the *Nervous Condition* when one makes a comparison between the way Babamukuru treats his son Chido and in the way that he treats Nyasha. He allows his son Chido to spend nights at his white friends' homes but cannot tolerate Nyasha coming home late. We come to learn from the novel that Chido has a white girlfriend and stays at friends' houses with girls but when Nyasha

arrives home late for simply speaking to a boy she is accused of 'whoreish' behaviour. Babamukuru is angered by his daughter's lack of obedience when he clearly states: "Children must be obedient, if they are not, they must be taught, So that they develop good habits. You know this is very important to me, especially in the case of girls. My wife here would not have disobeyed me" (*Nervous Condition*, 1988: 171). During this confrontation, Maiguru does not say anything, she stands aside and allows her husband to beat up Nyasha.

This action by married women also occurs in *Purple Hibiscus* (2003) when Eugene attacks Kambili with kicks and blows, Mama Stands aside and pleads "please biko!" (2003: 211). Mama unconsciously approves Papa's way of doing things and this presents submissiveness, piety and domesticity equivalent to Okonkwo's wives in Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* (1958) who stand aside as Okonkwo beats their co-wife Ojiugo. These actions by Mama and the other women also maps to what Maiguru does when Babamukuru assaults Nyasha in Dangaregmba's *Nervous Conditions*. Such behaviour from married women shows how patriarchy compels women to comply with its ideology through the use of violence. In the same vein, in Ngugi's *The River Between* (1965) Joshua's wife Miriamu takes his word without questioning, even when she thinks he is being unreasonable. Joshua does not care about his wife and even sends her away to go and look for Muthoni in the night. That is what being a mother meant, "It meant bearing on one's shoulders all the sins and misdeeds of the children" (1965: 33). The most important role of women and children is to be submissive and not disobey the male members and this is of the utmost importance in the Shona tradition. By defying her father, Nyasha is undermining Babamukuru's power and authority and in the heat of the argument Babamukuru tries to assert his dominance over his daughter once again and a physical fight breaks out between them:

How can you go about disgracing me? Me! Like that! No, you cannot do it. I am respected at this mission. I cannot have a daughter who behaves like a whore. She has dared to raise a fist to me ... to challenge me. Me! Her father. I am telling you today she shall not live. We cannot have two men in this house." (*Nervous Conditions*, 1988: 114 - 115)

The confrontation between Nyasha and Babamukuru greatly affected Tambu and she comes to the realisation that women will always be victimised regardless of where they find themselves. After this, she relates to Nyasha on another level and keeps wondering why her

uncle would condemn her cousin to whoredom, making her a victim of femaleness. Tambu relates this to the victimization she went through at home when Nhamo went to school and she had to stay at home and grow her maize. She realises that, “the victimization was universal and men took it with them everywhere” (*Nervous Conditions*, 1988: 118).

It can therefore be assumed that the unequal gender relations in the Sigauke clan can be associated with tradition. We can also affirm that one actual tragedy of the African women is a culture which hinders their progress and permanently sustains them in a state of submission. Ogundipe-Leslie (1994) identifies the socialization process which is gendered in that it connects macho strength and heroism to males and associates traditional roles of wife and mother with women. A woman’s honour and dignity in most cultures in Africa consists of strict adherence to idealized norms of wifehood and motherhood. Mutunda (2016) also lends his voice to the African woman’s condition when he states that beside procreation, a woman is expected to be a good and responsible wife to her husband. She is supposed to take care of first and foremost, her husband, attending to all his needs and desires and then the rest of the household roles. Mutunda (2016) further observes that, the woman is considered a wife and a mother, a care giver or nurturer, the one who provides for the nutritional needs of her family. He cites Diabah and Amfo (2015: 12) who posits that, the stereotype feminine role encompasses taking care of all kinds of domestic work such as cleaning, washing, cooking, etc... as well as bringing up children and making sure the family is supported. He further adds that as a homemaker, a woman is expected to be obedient to her husband, sharing his likes and dislikes, and respecting his relatives.

3.2.2. Marriage and Procreation as Vessels of Female Subjugation in *One is Enough*

The state of a woman in an African society, regardless of what part of Africa that society is, has always been an unfortunate one. This is because women always face deception, disappointment and exploitation. Nwapa in her novel *One is Enough* demonstrates the state of affairs of women in a Nigerian society. Through the protagonist of her novel Amaka, we see how women are deceived in marriage and subsequently made miserable. Nwapa visibly illustrates that the position of a woman in an Igbo society is predictable: she is meant to marry and procreate. Her personal independence within a value system that ultimately supports the community and the men who live within it is supposed to be limited to the good of the family. Even a woman’s money from her own trade business, which Amaka has, may benefit family members. Initially,

Amaka accepts these values which are also the cause of her negative self-image and her willingness to maintain her marriage to Obiora despite his cruelty and arrogance. In fact, she was so successful in her trading activities that she used to earn more than her husband and had even gifted a Peugeot car to him. But her husband did not want to make it known to his family and friends that the car had been purchased by his wife, so to save his reputation and also to appear superior to his wife he declared to everyone that he had purchased the car. Amaka does not want any issues to come into her relationship with her husband so she did not tell the truth and went along with her husband in whatever he wanted. These unequal power relations between men and women upon marriage are observed by Basow (1992) when she states: “The wife lost her legal existence and is considered an extension of her husband’s will and identity. A wife took on her husband’s name and place of residence, gave up her right to accuse her husband of rape (he was legally entitled to her sexual services) and agreed to provide domestic services without financial compensation (1992: 221). This can explain why Amaka at first conceals all the problems that she faced in her marriage from her family.

Despite her allegiance to her husband, Amaka is held in disdain by both Obiora and his mother because she is unable to have children. Her husband becomes ill-tempered, and almost inattentive to whatever she may have to say. Since she is a barren woman and has failed to meet the expectations of her community, Amaka becomes haunted by her community’s attitude. She does every possible thing to prove that she can be pregnant by visiting every gynecologist in the area. She lives with so much guilt because she has failed to bear a child for her husband six years after marriage. This is because the concept of motherhood has been of central importance in the traditions of African people. African patriarchy has relegated to African women the mythological role of mother thus every woman is expected to bear a child once they reached a child bearing age.

It is this thought that makes Amaka’s sterility to serve as a mark of her societal and ultimately her own humiliation. Cursed by her in-laws for having had no child after six years of marriage, Amaka kneels in front of her mother-in-law as if seeking forgiveness from an angry parent. Her efforts to assimilate to be the wife that the community permits are met with violence and physical abuse from her husband and ridicule from her mother-in-law. Amaka’s attempts to avoid the curse of being a “he” woman, one who challenges her husband in an argument, prove

to be futile. Her failure to challenge her husband in an argument, results in the confirmed belief that she is this dreaded social pariah (Mulchandani, 2014:8). The problem that Amaka faces as a wife, the shame of unfruitfulness is a major misfortune that could befall a woman in early African societies. Infertility is a major topic of discussion in many women authored novels such *Efuru* by Nwapa and Emecheta's *Joys of motherhood*; this shows how failure to procreate puts a woman in an awkward position in most African societies. If a couple is childless, the woman is said to be at fault. In such traditional societies, the incapability to conceive is nothing short of a crime, and such a woman is better off dead than alive. F. K. Buah in *A History of Ghana* (1980) gives his opinion about the importance of motherhood in African societies from a patriarchal point of view. According to him, a "fruitful" marriage should have children, if not it must be considered as a "non-blessed" marriage and most of the times the result of it could be divorce. This line of thought is proved by the fact that Amaka's marriage to Obiora ends in divorce and the sole reason was because she could not give him a child. In most African societies a woman that cannot have children, "the barren woman" is seen as evil. On the other hand, the one who bears many children, preferably sons, acquires a higher status and is considered blessed. She is thus, respected and mythologized. Moore (1986) advances the idea of women's procreation further by pointing out that, when a married man has children, it "signifies the productive potential of his household, the successful nature of his marriage, the continuation of lineage" (1986: 69). A man is regarded as wealthy when he has a significant herd of cattle, a large piece of land and many children. For a woman on the other hand, the birth of children is the confirmation of her sexuality, the guarantee of her social status and the provision for her old age.

In most African societies, motherhood is the foundation on which the family is developed. This concept partly explains why a man's family researches a woman's family history before marriage; for it is the mothers who will not only assure that generations will continue but will also instruct the children in moral goodness and the community's beliefs and practices. It is important for the mothers and elders to properly socialize the young ones in tradition. Children represent wealth for families either through working on the land or, in the case of girls, bringing in bride-wealth. Thus, a mother's role is very important; moreover, as Edeh (1985) observes, "community life begins in the family, and a family is not formed until all marriage customs are fulfilled" (Edeh, 1985: 57). The importance of children in the home can explain the reason why Obiora fathers two children behind Amaka's back. Despite the fact that

men in some of these African traditions are allowed to take up more than one wife, Obiora decides to betray his wife.

The state of affairs leave Amaka completely helpless but there isn't much she can do as society seemingly blames her for having failed to give her husband children. After marrying, Amaka and Obiora appear happy with each other, with their jobs, and with their friends, but there is no sign of the pregnancy expected by traditional Igbo values and this situation causes a rift between them. To make matters even worse, Obiora's mother insists; "Obiora must have an heir because all his brothers and sisters have an heir" (*One is Enough*, 12). This makes Amaka to feel so frustrated and tries to find a way to satisfy her mother-in-law. She tries to make her mother-in-law believe that she has an appointment with a medical doctor, but the mother-in-law knows the truth. To further humiliate Amaka, her mother-in-law blurts out that Obiora has two sons by another woman, and the woman and her sons are coming to live with Obiora and Amaka. Amaka finds it hard to overcome this hostility and emptiness at the same time. She wonders if she is "useless to the world because she was childless? Was she unfulfilled because she had no child?" (22).

Amaka finds herself in such a situation because Africa has no place for barrenness and delayed pregnancy in marriage. Even though these are modern times, it can be noted that this mentality has not changed. The people of Nigeria for example are very particular when it comes to childbearing and this is what Nwapa tries to show in *One is Enough*. The African man and society gives top priority to procreation and in other societies a male child is greatly preferred. In traditional African society, barrenness and delayed pregnancy was even seen as an abominable act and women who were not able to have children were even suspected to be witches. The cruelty among the African people on barren women goes beyond mention. This is because when a woman delays in conceiving or fails to do so, more wives will be married with her or even replaced totally. In the African context, a barren woman is no woman. She is just an object that must be replaced for the family name to survive. Childbirth is seen to be the essence of womanhood and the goal of marriage.

According to Mutunda in (2015), even among the Lunda people of North-Western Zambia, procreation is also so crucial like in any other parts of Africa in that. In this society, if a woman appears to be barren, the husband is justified in marrying a second wife who will be able

to bear him children. These views on motherhood can be seen through the attitude of both Amaka's aunt and her mother's. The aunt tells Amaka that marriage is not as important as children or as important as being able to have children. According to her, "A marriage is no marriage without children. Have your children, be able to look after them, and you will be respected" (*One is Enough*, 8). Earlier in the novel when Amaka's two suitors died and she was feeling unfortunate, her mother advised her: "Marriage or no marriage, have children". She further states that, "your children will take care of you in your old age. You will be very lonely then if you don't have children. As a mother, you are fulfilled" (*One is Enough*, 11).

This thought of Amaka's mother is similar to that of Nnu Ego in Emecheta's *Joys of Motherhood* (1979) who believes that children were supposed to take care of one when they grow old. They believe that a woman without a child would have her old age doomed to loneliness as there would be no child to care for her or mourn her death in view of the honour that a woman has on attaining motherhood, and the disadvantages she faces when she fails to reproduce, Helen Chukwuma (1990) reports in her article, *Voices and Choices: The Feminist Dilemma in Four African Novels* that;

The problem of the marriage institution in a feministic situation is the limitation it imposes on the woman. A wife loses her individuality and when she becomes a mother, her power and status are reflected in her children. If she has no children, any meaningful status evades her. (1990: 139)

The stress here is on children, motherhood, and reverence, with motherhood being the final goal. Amaka's aunt sees marriage as typically an opportunity for making children. She explains that she didn't like her husband when she married him but had seven children by him and then decided she did not want to sleep with him anymore. She had accomplished her mission: motherhood. She then finds a second wife for her husband and focuses on her business. Afterwards Amaka realises that love had had nothing to do with her aunt's and her mother's marriages; motherhood was their goal and thus she also had to work on being a mother. This attitude and thoughts on motherhood can be seen to be very common among most Africans. For instance, the Lunda say: "*mutondu kufukama wudi namaфу*" ("For a tree to bend it needs to have leaves that will make it heavy") implying that the value of a woman lies on her ability to bear

children; the more children she bears, the more respected she becomes” (Mutunda, 2015: 516). This explains why Amaka feels complete when she finally bears children. In the same vein, in Nwapa’s novel *Efuru*, the concept of motherhood becomes Efuru’s biggest problem when she delays in conceiving after marriage. Even though she had ignored courtship traditions, Efuru follows the cultural tradition on motherhood. This outcry for children as symbols of family posterity, the pride of a woman and the foundation of marriages, make the people of Onitsha in Nwapa’s *One is Enough* to think of childlessness as evil and the greatest misfortune that can befall any couple.

It should be mentioned that in most African societies, if a woman does not bear any children, her husband is free to take up a second wife. Polygamy has existed in most parts of Africa and this is due to some aspects of the African culture and religion. One reason for this is because African societies considered children as source of wealth and so, in this way, a family with more children was seen to be very powerful. This is also the reason why most men whose wives fail to bear children end up taking a second wife. This is because in the African culture, every marriage is expected to have children. According to Mears Mary (2009: 105) in some African cultures such as the Igbo of Nigeria, a wife can sometimes find a woman or a concubine to bear children on her behalf if she is unable to do so. Since there must be male children in order to inherit money and other properties from the husband, this practice is exercised by women who are barren or are widows or those who do not have male children in order to assure their receiving inheritances. Mears (2009: 106) cites Nwapa’s characters who employ the practice of “woman marriage” in her novels *Idu* (1971) and *Efuru* (1966). When Idu realizes that she is having trouble conceiving after a certain period of time, she talks to her husband about getting a second wife for him. A character, the inquisitive, difficult Onyemuru, also stresses, however, the significance of following Igbo tradition in which wives “permit” husbands to marry additional wives so there will be children in the family. Onyemuru says, “If Idu can’t have a child, let her allow her husband to marry another wife. That’s what our people do. There are many girls around” (*Idu*, 33). Tradition is important to the female characters, for Nwasobi responds to Onyemuru by saying, “you speak the truth. . . . I shall speak with Idu” (*Idu*, 34). However despite this custom, Obiora chooses not to discuss his second wife and two sons with Amaka. Amaka is not asked or told about the second wife before Obiora marries her and before the birth

of the children. Thus, Obiora has decided not to obey customs and this breaks Amaka's heart. In her depressed state, she expresses her sorrow to her husband in this way:

Congratulations. I thought that in this sort of thing, a wife, even a barren one should have been taken into confidence. It beats me how you should do all this behind my back, be involved with a woman, have sons by her, marry her without breathing a word to your wife. You have changed a good deal my husband. (*One is Enough*, 26)

In addition, Amaka feels she is not shown any respect by her husband or mother-in-law when they inform her that the second wife and the boys are coming to live in the house with everyone. After the wife and boys arrive, Obiora continues to insult Amaka by demanding that she recognize the new family members according to his expectations. The narrator shows that Amaka makes an attempt to be courteous but also to stand up for herself. She asks, "Where is the mother of your sons?" and Obiora responds by saying, "You mean my wife?" (*One is Enough*, 25). Thus he tells Amaka that she must refer to the woman as his wife. Polygamy, as presented in the text, can be seen as an institution used by men to subjugate women. It allows men to marry as many wives as possible for diverse reasons and none of these reasons take the woman's feelings into consideration. As can be seen in *One is Enough*, the decision that Obiora takes leaves Amaka completely devastated. In the same way in Efuru's case, her mother in-law does not harshly speak to her but secretly she wishes Efuru and her son would marry a second wife to give children to the family and remove the social stigma from the family.

Barbara Christian's (1985) views here may seem appropriate as she says that even though motherhood is valued, it is "universally imposed upon women as their sole identity, above all others" (1985: 212). This reverence of motherhood can hence be seen as intrinsically contributing to the subjugation of women. It can also be said that Polygamous marriages further lower women's role in traditional African societies and Butengwa (1993) sees this practice as another way of exploiting the African woman (1993: 28). Women are forced to give in to their husbands' longing for more relations, and the emotional scars that one has due to this practice are not given attention. At times African men seek additional wives regardless of their socio-economic status. In some of these situations men fail to cope with the demands of having more

than one household. This is portrayed in *Nervous Conditions* where Takesure, a distant cousin of Babamukuru, had supposedly come to help Jeremiah in the fields. Actually, when he came to Jeremiah's homestead he was running away from his two wives, for he had no means of supporting them.

Another aspect that is important in the African culture is that of marriage and is used as a medium of enslaving women. This is because it is preferred over single life in the most African communities, and polygamy is also highly acceptable, even though most people practice monogamy. A woman in an African society is highly respected when she is married and it can be said that marriage is just as important as motherhood. Amaka, the protagonist of the story despite being presented as a caring, thoughtful, ambitious, and determined young woman who at sixteen, wants to be married and is "going to show everybody that a woman's ambition was marriage, a home that she could call her own, a man she would love, desire and cherish, and children to crown the marriage" (*One is Enough*, 1). Regardless of her desire to get married, Amaka faces many difficulties while courting and because of the traditional expectations of the community that she lives in, she is put under a lot of pressure. Her first suitor, Obi, is well liked by her mother and comes from a well-respected family. According to the narrator, "The understanding that both families would be in-laws had been fully established when news came to Amaka's mother that the young man had married another girl in church" (*One is Enough*, 6). This unexplained change in Obi's actions, which indicates a break in tradition. He and Amaka have been promised to each other through their families' negotiations at an earlier time; however, Obi attends Christian schools and learns ideas that differ from Igbo cultural practices about marriage. Thus, he decides to exercise his option to marry a young lady whom he chooses without considering cultural expectations, even the obligatory commitment that has been made for him, and he does not show any unease for Amaka's feelings or the expectations of the community. Although Amaka is heartbroken for a while, her mother advises her to "forget the man," she declares he is not good for her, and says it is good he left her before the marriage. This encourages Amaka's sole ambition to be a wife and Mother.

When she begins to date another man Isaac and dates him for one year without him proposing marriage, people in the community begin to question Amaka, causing her great embarrassment. Some of her friends' advice that she sees other men while seeing Isaac but

Amaka refuses to take their advice even though she really wants to get married. It is clear the community voices are supporting marriage. Marriage in the African context can therefore be seen to be the true trial of womanhood. As Helen Chukwuma (2006) asserts, “The true test for female assertion is in the marriage institution and motherhood. It is in the home that the real fight for women identity and survival is waged” (2006: 31). The African culture has created an atmosphere that makes a woman to look down on herself when she is unmarried or even childless. Adrienne Rich, as cited by Rosemarie Tong, had suggested that, “Men have convinced women that unless a woman is a mother she is not really a woman” (2009: 87). A woman is expected to rise above the limit that is set by tradition for women in her culture. Even when a woman fails to meet ‘expectations’ in a marriage, African culture portrays the woman as one who can be replaced. But when the same concept of replacement in marriage is on the side of woman, it is seen as a taboo.

Men can be polygamists, but the same cannot be said of women. As a much respected establishment in traditional Africa, the purpose for marriage has been for reproduction and company, as well as for one to be accorded respect in the society as a responsible individual. This is evident in *One is Enough* as children and marriage are so highly valued among the Onitsha community that procreation is considered the one and only reason for marriage. To them, children are blessings to the community, the pride of every woman and the strength of every race. This is why Amaka’s dream as a teenager had been to get married and have children of her own. In African tradition, marriage between two persons is well-thought-out to be purely a family matter and not that of the two people involved. Among the Bemba people of Northern Zambia for instance, it is the elders of the two parties involved that are in charge of the marriage negotiations. Therefore, the issue of elopement is completely unacceptable. To this end, certain rites are performed in order for marriage to be binding such as wine-carrying, wealth-price payment, among others. Above all, for any marriage to be successful in certain African settings it must be blessed with children, especially males, else it is doomed.

Marriage can be said to confer certain rights on a wife and corresponding duties on a husband. The man acquires certain rights after he has performed all necessary customs and is expected to protect and feed the wife and children. This is why a woman’s education is seen to be useless in Dangaregmba’s *Nervous Conditions*. In the text, both Jeremiah and Babamukuru

agreed that Tambuzai's sharpness with her books was of no use. They believed it was the duty of a male child of raising their family from hunger. As Babamukuru observes; "Tambu must be given an opportunity to do what she can do for the family before she goes to her husband's home" (*Nervous Conditions*, 55). From the statement of Babamukuru it can be seen that the family has already got plans for Tambu's marriage and after he enrolls Tambu into the mission school, he advises even her to be good with her books and also to develop into a good woman. He tells her that it was necessary for her to be a good girl, "There is nothing that pleases parents more than to see their children settled into their own families," he further states that, "I know that these things are very far away but it is never too early to begin to plan for your future" (*Nervous Conditions*, 88). It can therefore be assumed that marriage is the hope and future for all girls, and most have to engage themselves in it because there are many parties that have interest in this institution. Failure to get married or have children ultimately makes women to feel troubled because tradition has already prescribed the way in which a woman's life is supposed to progress. This thus contributes to the oppression and subjugation of women as they feel unfulfilled when they fail to meet the cultural expectations of the communities in which they live. This has clearly been revealed in Nwapa's *One is Enough*.

3.2.3. Sexual Violence in The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me

Sexual violence in African societies has been rampant both in traditional and modern societies. This can also be seen to have been influenced by the traditional values and beliefs where a woman was seen as a sexual object whose sole duty is to provide sexual satisfaction to men. As discussed earlier, this is because most cultures perceive men to be superior and women to be socially and culturally inferior and this is why sexual violence is especially directed towards female and adolescents who lack the economic status to resist or avoid it. The abuse can be in the form of sexual assault, sexual exploitation, female genital mutilation and this is what Calixthe Beyala tries to exemplify in her novel *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* (1987) in which her main character, a nineteen year old, Ateba faces many struggles while living with her aunt Ada in the slums of Douala called the QG - (Quartier Général). In the text, Beyala gives a portrayal of the lives of the rural dwellers who have left their impoverished villages in the hope of economic gain in the city.

Regardless of these people's movements, it can be noted that mostly it is the women that are the heads of these households and remain economically and socially disadvantaged usually earning a living from little trade and prostitution. Through Ateba, the protagonist of the story, it can be noted that most women of these slums fully depend on the men as a result, there are high levels of prostitution. This patriarchal mentality is what causes aunt Ada to control Ateba's future by negotiating her marriage with a wealthy man. Ada temporarily imprisons the young woman by controlling her body and her movements in accordance with an exacting principle of virginity. To assure herself of Ateba's virginity, she forces her to endure the humiliating "egg test" to prove that she was still submissive and intact. As Mutunda (2016) rightly points out, "this harmful practice [. . .] gives sexual pleasure to man, while robbing [Ateba] of pleasure during sex" (2016: 716). It is worth noting that here, Beyala tries to show the complicity of women in rituals that perpetuate patriarchy and abuse women's bodies. These practices are cruel and can be seen to be at the centre of female oppression.

Atebe's life also takes a turn for the worst when her aunt Ada rents out a room to a man called Jean Zepp. From the time he begins to live in this house, Jean Zepp becomes a force of disorder and disturbs the peace in the house which was once a female domestic space. Once in the house, Jean Zepp turns into a male predator and becomes a dangerous trap for Ateba. On one occasion when she comes to Jean's room with a neighbour's message, she accidentally finds him in bed with a woman and he punishes her for her contravention.

He forces her down low, forces her to crouch. With her head punished into his manly smells, her mouth against his penis, she says to herself he's gone completely mad, that she's gone completely mad since she is responsible for what happens to her...on her knees, her face raised to the sky....the position of the offending woman since time immemorial....on the floor... crouched. (*The Sun*, 24)

This incident causes her a lot of humiliation and she inwardly resents Jean Zepp and her aunt because they want to force sexual activities on her. He does not end here but rather continues to threaten Ateba by continually abusing her both physically and sexually. This kind of sexual assault clearly shows how women are treated in patriarchal societies. According to Mutunda

(2015: 115), Jean Zepp views women as mere objects to be conquered and the penis as the ultimate weapon with which to dominate and subdue them. Mutunda (2015) further states that giving the penis the same power as a weapon, Jean Zepp uses it to assert his masculine power and superiority. This clearly shows that in this community, a woman has no other value than to provide sexual pleasure to a man. Hence, once his lust has been satisfied, women have no value to him. For instance, two years before when one of his mistresses tried to kiss him before getting dressed, he had pushed her away brutally and got up, [then told her]: a woman was good only in the evening melting into the dark. No, the daytime was absolutely not made for her. . . . Who had said that woman was beautiful? The guys must have two black holes instead of eyes! (*The Sun*, 43).

This attitude of men can also be seen in another of Beyala's text *Your Name Shall be Tanga* (1996) in which Tanga is treated like a whore by all the men around her. At the age of six, her father pushes her off into the corner of his bedroom while he has sex with another woman. When she is ten years old, her father rapes her and poisons the child who results from this incestuous encounter. By the time she is sixteen a lot of men had taken advantage of her. Like Ateba, she clearly expresses her frustrations at the beginning of the novel: "I fell heir to the blood between my legs. To a hole between my thighs. All that I was left with was the law of oblivion. Time passed, I was becoming accustomed to that part of me that was gone" (*Your Name*, 12). It can be noted that the men in these novels sexually abuse these women without any feeling of obligation and it can be said that it is because society has given men the authority. The women are sexually objectified and abused and are not even able to control their sexuality. This is why women even after getting married are of the view that their sole obligation is to satisfy the male sexually when there are other important things that are attached to this institution. They have become victims of patriarchal society's oppression for society views respectable women as those who are submissive and live under the protection of a powerful man.

These views that African society has of women is what has given the men ultimate power over women. These men feel like they have the power to possess their women. In *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*, it is evident that all the men in the text have authority over women. For example, when there is a police raid in the QG, an officer forces Ateba to follow him into an abandoned shed, where he sexually abuses her (*The Sun Hath*, 70). This incident can also be

compared to the one in *Your Name Shall be Tanga* (1996) where a military general sexually abuses her. The fact that these men have got power makes them think they have the right to abuse the women. According to Mutunda (2015: 117), physical power has contributed to the authority that the men has over women. He further states that the men believe that their power is God- given and that is why some men even use monetary power to exercise their masculinity over women. To stress his point, (Mutunda, 2015: 116) cites an incident in the text in which the anonymous rich client Ateba picks up in a bar after her friend Irene's funeral gives himself rights over her own body: "Your body belongs to me until dawn. Another day I might have been able to let you go. But tonight I need an imprint of a woman in my bed" (*The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*, 118). When Ateba tries to leave his apartment, he grabs her wrists and hair, forcing her to kneel and perform oral sex. This display of physical power complements his claim that, "God has sculpted woman on her knees at the feet of man" (*The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*, 118). Beyala's portrayal of such attitude by men clearly shows that women have to give in to such things but are on the other hand disgusted and tired of this behaviour by men. She also tries to show that this gender stereotyping and men's unreasonable expectations is agonizing. For instance in *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*, Ateba's best friend, Irene, describes an incident in which she is disrespected by a white man:

Monsieur asks me to suck his thing. . . . Tiny and all red. He doesn't insist. In short – he throws me on the bed, he jumps on me, he rubs himself, caresses my breasts, my belly, my clitoris. "I want to give you pleasure," he says as he drools over me. And as for me, I look at him with eyes rolling as if I were already coming. (75)

Mutunda's (2015) thought that man uses his ultimate weapon, the penis, to conquer and subdue a woman can therefore be said to be true. Beyala shows that the men view women as sexual objects to use in order to satisfy their sexual desire. They are sexual predators who consider women as prey to be hunted down and conquered (Mutunda, 2015: 125).

CHAPTER FOUR: FEMINIST VOICE IN THE SELECTED WOMEN NOVELS

The female character has emerged from her cocoon,
basking free to a mixed reception of surprise and wonder.

Helen Chukwuma. (1989)

The story of the marginalization and invisibility of women without a voice is a familiar one and is wide spread in most African fiction. As shown in the preceding chapters, women have been stereotyped and made subservient because of their sex and this is the picture that permeates most male authored literary texts. Consequently, African women have come together and written different texts that try to change and revive the face of the African woman. Their commitment to female realistic portrayal shows the vital role of women and the complexities of African women's own world. Women started to make their suffering voice heard by giving fuller accounts of their situation. They endeavoured to depict women abandoned by their fathers, disempowered or abused by men, and their reaction to all these forces. This is what Dangaremba, Beyala and Nwapa demonstrate in their texts.

According to Mohanty (2003), it is necessary for Third World women to speak for themselves, to rewrite their history and to produce knowledge about themselves. She suggests that the important question is: who is speaking for Third World women and from what geographical location they are doing so? (2003: 52). The women writers whose texts I have selected try to show through their female characters that women have got the power and are determined to speak out for themselves, stop male oppression and break the stereotypical and biased ideals practiced in their society. They show that women too can make choices and be free from the grip of patriarchy despite what culture says about them. These female writers have created characters that have a voice and are able to assert themselves in the societies in which they live.

4.1. Discovering Self- Identity and Happiness

Nwapa's novel *One is Enough* has been described as "a female bildungsroman" (Stratton, 1999: 86) because Amaka becomes "a self-assertive, self-authenticating woman" (1999: 86). For Amaka, the journey of transformation is initiated by her failure to meet the stereotypical

expectation of her Igbo community, which is highlighted in her in-law's caustic words: "I shouted it from the rooftops. I told Obiora not to marry you, that you were going to be barren" (*One is Enough*, 5). It is at this point that Amaka realizes that she must seek an alternative in which she can restore her true sense of self and dignity. She resolves to choose and create a new identity for herself in which she can find happiness. Thus, she leaves her marriage with Obiora and moves to Lagos city to establish herself and ensure her freedom and peace as an individual. She leaves her marriage because married life had caged, exploited, humiliated, oppressed, and reduced her self-esteem.

Whilst in Lagos, she approaches life with a new philosophy and it is here that her journey to self-fulfillment begins. She uses her charming good look to make influential men fall in love with her and help her become a successful business woman. It can be noted that in such a society, if a woman aspires to become financially prosperous, sexual bargaining is an open and guaranteed choice. Encouraged by her sister who is a mistress of a Nigerian business man, she prospers. After she is introduced to Alhaji, Amaka finds her sense of independence and self-worth as a woman. This is because Alhaji is influential and this helps her get government contracts. Through these contracts, Amaka is able to become financially secure and rent her own apartment, buy a car, build a house in her hometown, give money to family members and divorce her husband legally and traditionally by returning her bride-price.

Mulchandani Neelam (2014: 9) in *One is Enough: Rejection of Voicelessness and a Quest for self-Assertion*, cites Berrian (1995) who comments that having been thrown out of her home while functioning as a dutiful wife, Amaka no longer sees the world through her communities' eyes. In a conversation with her friend Adaobi, she thus describes life in urban Lagos: "You know Lagos. No man can do anything for a woman, without asking her for her precious possession – herself. I must confess to you, I have slept with the Alhaji" (*One is Enough*, 68). Nwapa shows that when Amaka entertains Alhaji, she does not do that as a prostitute; rather, it is because she finds herself in a society where it is the only means by which a woman can achieve her goals. In other words, Amaka is using what is available – i.e. her charm and beauty – to have what she desires.

In Lagos Amaka becomes a free woman and has so many business opportunities. Despite this, she decides to remain single and it is her choice to live the single life that allots her the opportunity to meet a Catholic priest named Father McLaid, who innocently helps Amaka to achieve her most desired goal, motherhood. Amaka and Father McLaid are committed to each other, but because of their positions, they keep their relationship private. When Amaka first meets Father McLaid and develops an intimate relationship with him, the whole purpose was to seduce him so as she can get some business contracts, but this relationship results into having twin boys; as narrator declares: “She wanted just one thing from him at the time, a base where she would gain contract jobs, make money and live an independent life. Her association with the priest was not motivated by any feeling of affection, least of all love, at the beginning” (*One is Enough*, 102). She is quite surprised to learn that she is pregnant because she thought she was barren; however, she is very happy. Both apologize to each other for manipulating each other for selfish purposes and the priest declares that he would take care of her and his children.

Despite Amaka’s joy upon discovering that she is pregnant and not barren as thought by her former mother-in-law, she decides that she does not want to and will not marry Father McLaid just because she has children by him, even though he wants to marry her to save his moral reputation with the public. Amaka’s rejection and her sense of freedom are expressed in the following excerpt:

I don’t want to be a wife . . . A mistress, yes, but not a wife . . . As a wife, I am never free. I am a shadow of myself. As a wife I am almost impotent. I am in prison, unable to advance in body and soul. Something gets hold of me as a wife and destroys me. . . . No, I am through with husbands. I said farewell to husbands the first day I came to Lagos. (*One is Enough*, 127)

Although her mother insists that she gets married to father McLaid after she has his twins children, Amaka does not heed her mother’s advice and she tells the priest that “the journey to her home for the marriage rites [has] been postponed indefinitely” (*One is Enough*, 149); in other words, there would be no marriage. These words indicate that Amaka has discovered herself. Although the mother wants Amaka to marry Father McLaid for varied reasons such as protection from other men, some help in bringing up the boys, she only heeds the advice of her sister Ayo and Nanny who tells her: “If you don’t feel like it, don’t do it . . . I am

much older than you are, and know how you feel. So I can see you do not want him [Izu] as a husband. Don't let your mother push you into this kind of marriage" (*One is Enough*, 148-49). Flora Nwapa here tries to show that women should stand up for their rights and not allow their decisions to be influenced by what society expects them to be or do. Amaka takes Izu the priest who father's her twins as her lover only because he is able to give her pleasure, converse with her on a respectful level, and is the intermediary to obtain her building contracts. The narrator describes how Amaka feels: "She neither wanted to be a wife any more, nor be a mistress, or even a kept woman. She wanted a man; just a man and she wanted to be independent of this man, pure and simple" (*One is Enough*, 100). She has rejected the deep rooted social traditions, including marriage and accepted the challenge of leading a life of her own without a man on her side. According to Ezeigbo (1998), *One is Enough* is Nwapa's "forthright encouragement of childless women to look for other ways of living a self-fulfilled and profitable life" (1998: 65).

Just like Efuru in Nwapa's *Efuru*, Amaka breaks away from the barriers of culture and religion by asserting her identity, and freedom in her society. In Lagos, she has a new beginning without limitations but with many expectations. Amaka's reaction to the unjust or biased culture of her society depicts Nwapa's view that women should learn to be self-reliant in or outside marriages, whether they have children of their own or not. Amaka's revolting action shows that Nwapa in this text exemplifies that women do not need to suffer social or cultural humiliations but must stand up to challenge or break off with these inhibitions and choose their own better alternative. Through Amaka, we see the feminist spirit of independence and determination. The humiliation that Amaka undergoes in her marriage and in society makes her decide to take her destiny in her own hands. This is why she quits her marriage and decides to live and survive in life without depending on any man. To survive as well as the spirit of not succumbing to humiliation and defeat. Her significant success in business changes everything and makes her the envy of the community in which she was once scorned. These actions and achievements of Amaka support Helen Chukwuma's (1990) position that economic independence is a source of female self-assertion, breaking loose the shackles of subjugation and establishing choice as the basis of interaction (1990: 133).

This decision by Amaka is clearly expressed in her specific words: “I don’t want to be a wife anymore. . . . As a wife, I am never free. . . . No, I am through with husbands. I said farewell to husbands the day I came to Lagos” (*One is Enough*, 127). A similar decision has also been made by Chinwe, the daughter of Dora in Nwapa’s *Women are Different* (1986) when she divorces her unstable husband in order to concentrate on her business. Nwapa here states clearly that:

Chinwe had done the right thing. Her generation was doing better than her mother’s own. Her generation was telling the men, that there are different ways of living one’s life fully and fruitfully. They were saying that women, have options. Their lives cannot be ruined because of a bad marriage. They have a choice, a choice to marry and have children, a choice to marry or divorce their husbands. Marriage is not THE only way (*Women are Different*, 3).

According to Chukwuma (2006: 9), women writers make their female protagonists burst the marriage institution when it becomes too subjugating. Chukwuma gives an example of Amaka in *One is Enough*, Firdaus in *Woman at Point Zero*, Aissatou in *So Long a Letter*, Adah in *Second Class Citizen*, Adaku in *Joys of Motherhood* and others, who all go away from their matrimonial homes, distancing themselves physically and psychologically to seek their individuality and self-realization in the wider world.

Amaka does not make her decision not to marry again in haste. At first, she questions herself in terms of her past, present, and future. After she gives birth to her twins, she invites Obiora to her mother’s house and it is during the visit that she questions herself, seeking the truth: “Was this man the husband with whom she had lived with for six years? She felt nothing for him anymore. . . . Was this the man she loved so much and married? Why did she feel nothing towards him anymore?” (*One is Enough*, 119). She also thinks of what her family members would say if they found out that it was a priest who had fathered her children. However, when she asks her sister, Ayo, about the situation, she is urged to follow her own feelings. It is then that she finally recognizes that she does not feel anything special or intimate for Izu. She wonders what is wrong with her and whether she is incapable of loving anyone anymore. Amaka

comes to the conclusion that she does not want to love anyone except her twins and family. She arrives at a clear understanding of what is best for her as a woman, a mother, and a businesswoman. To detach herself from the restraints of marriage therefore, she pays back her bride-price to Obiora's family, thereby freeing herself of whatever her community may think of her earlier childless life. It should be noted that, Amaka's repayment of the bride-price to Obiora is most significant to her as it symbolises her new independence in several respects. By returning the sum of money which Obiora had forwarded in order to "purchase" his bride from her family, Amaka no longer "belongs" to him. Hence it would appear that transformation for Amaka occurs largely through financial emancipation. Amaka also rejects Obiora when he decides that he should take her back. In the text, Nwapa through her character Amaka upholds that a woman need not be subsumed by marriage; neither should she be intimidated by spinsterhood (Chukwuma, 1994: 125).

Survival and individuality have been the important influences in Amaka's decision to remain a single mother; and her difficult journey from a single woman to a married, childless woman to an unmarried mother and successful business woman, shows that a woman can achieve her goals and find personal happiness without a man on her side. She represents independence for women within an evolving post-colonial society. Nwapa in the text reveals the many ways in which the oppressed female characters could be free and the approaches they could use in order to break loose from unjust tradition and culture that subjugate, humiliate and deny women their pride in both the traditional and modern society. Nwapa's characters seem to break the societal norms in order to assert themselves and; as Chukwuma contains in *Women's Quest for Rights: African Feminist Theory in Fiction*, it is after women have become successful in their dissent that they are acclaimed by society and their erstwhile husbands. They are not condemned nor ostracized. They are rather accorded recognition and respect (2006: 4). What Nwapa and all the female writers are advocating for is personhood. Chukwuma (2006) further states that by urging women to break out of subsuming norms and situations such as the marriage institution, they stand the enormous risk of being dubbed cultural deviationists. For the marriage institution is sacred to culture, tradition and religion. But the truth of the matter is that a dreaded disease needs a correspondingly drastic cure. Thus, the ways women writers liberated their women characters from the gendered yoke was to make them burst the system and be free. By the time the shock waves subside, the lesson would have been learnt (Chukwuma, 2006: 5).

Charles Nnolim (2000) in his discussion of Nwapa's women's characters writes: "The lesson? Women shall never stop suffering at the hands of men. But the women's saving grace, their last redoubt, lies in being economically independent" (2000: 113). In similar vein, Marie Umeh (1998) is of the view that Nwapa's "canonical contribution to Nigerian letters is then a poetics of economic independence and self-reliance for female empowerment. She cites Nwapa stating: "[. . .] I feel that every woman, married or single, must have economic independence. If you look at *One is Enough*, I quote a Hausa proverb which says "a woman who holds her husband as a father dies an orphan". According to Umeh's (1998) interpretation of the proverb, this means that a woman should be economically independent. One should not rely on inheritance or men for survival (1998: 670). This can be said to be the reason why Nwapa's female characters are assertive. Even Amaka's aunt seems to understand the importance of education, for she tells Amaka how she educated her children from the profits she earned from her business. She also makes it evident in the text that women must have their own businesses and never depend entirely on husbands. The aunt advises Amaka: "Never slave for him. Have your own business no matter how small, because you never can tell" (*One is Enough*, 9).

The above sentiments support Carole Davies' (1986) views about African Feminism. Davies reminds the reader that the African woman is aware of the inequities and limitations in traditional society, a view espoused by Amaka's mother, who explains why she did not marry for love and what she did when she had had enough children by her husband. Amaka's mother and aunt also support Davies' fifth characteristic of feminism, which focuses on women's being self-reliant and never depending completely on the husband. Again, Amaka's mother explains that she married younger wives to take care of her husband's sexual needs while she pursued her business interests. Lastly, both women encourage Amaka to have children whether she is married or not; it is a "traditional and contemporary avenue of choice" Njoku contends that the actions of the aunt and mother push Amaka towards a "womanist consciousness" when they advise her to be financially independent of her husband (*One is Enough*, 6).

Brenda Berrian's (1995:53) argument that Nwapa has invented the African woman and placed her within the global perspective of politics, commerce and independence can be said to be true. In *One is Enough* for example, female solidarity is dramatically exemplified by the group called the "Cash Madams," women who own their own land and houses in Lagos and their

hometowns. They represent a new breed of female entrepreneurs and invite Amaka to join them. Six are widows; four have left their husbands to start a new life. The “Cash Madams” become successful during the Biafra Civil War when they sell products to soldiers on both sides to feed their families. They are often referred to as being part of the “attack trade” for selling to the enemies. The “Cash Madams” find it necessary to move to Lagos after the war in order to remain economically independent and do not define themselves solely by marriage and children. The cash madams invite Amaka to join them and this shows that women have the power to collaborate for self-advancement and family security. The women in the text build up and encourage one another as they share their financial success and stories. For instance, Amaka helps Adaobi get contracts, and Adaobi builds a house for her family without her husband’s knowledge.

Berrian (1995) further argues that, what Nwapa does is to stimulate a serious probing of social and moral issues that confront the Igbo woman in her everyday life. Berrian, in declaring her feminist stand in the Nigerian novel, argues that “the traditional village society emerges favouring and emphasizing the importance of men and de-emphasizing the role of women so that women garner only a subordinate status deeply rooted in their dual roles as mother and wife” (Berrian, 1995: 53). This position always leaves the woman with no option other than to choose an alternative life-style outside marriage like the case of Amaka in *One is Enough*. The views expressed by Amaka, Ayo, Adaobi, and the “Cash Madams” indicate that a new kind of woman is willing to work to make their own paths in society. The positive outcome is that the women are now being accepted by society, especially in cities, and some of the new ideas are transmitted to rural counterparts who desire the same results. These women see themselves as human and not just sexual beings for procreation. Amaka, her sister, and Adaobi are a part of the first generation of new women, exhibiting more flexible ideas about how to live life, as shown in the discussion of marriage and motherhood between Amaka and her mother. Amaka, who represents the younger and educated generation, accepts motherhood but does not believe it is the only goal in life and does not think the lack of motherhood should diminish a person as a worthwhile individual.

Before proceeding with my discussion I need to mention that, Nwapa allows Amaka and the other female characters to privilege themselves in newly emerging, evolving levels of consciousness while establishing their dignity and earning respect from people in their rural hometowns as well as Lagos. Thus, Nwapa has successfully navigated the options for women in Igbo society and is advocating balance and diversity within the community. An adjusting traditional consciousness and an emerging contemporary consciousness form the driving force that creates the novel's dialogue within self and between self, family, and society—all set in the narrator and guided by the implied author—that has come full circle from *Efuru* to *One is Enough*.

4.2. Destroying the Phallic Symbol, Source of oppression and Violence

Like in Nwapa's novel, in *The Sun Hath Looked upon Me*, Beyala through her character Ateba, also challenges patriarchal control over women. Ateba gets fed up of the sexual violence in the QG and the dehumanizing way in which the women in their slums are treated and her reaction was through violence. When one of the QG prostitutes Irene who was also Ateba's close friend dies after a botched abortion, she takes on the role of prostitute confronting a male predator in closed space, her clients room. There, in a fit of fury, she murders the man who abuses her. The act of murder was described as follows:

I see the woman unfolding her wings, spitting the sperm at the man's feet. Flinging a heavy copper ashtray at his skull. I see him reeling a few minutes at this repeated assault by the woman, then he crashed to the floor. . . . She had crouched down, grabbed the man's head and with two hands she is beating it against the stone floor. The blood gushes out, splatters, sullies. She gives a beat to her blows, scanning 'Irene, Irene' and as she still notices signs of life under her hands, she picks up a knife and, overcome with joy, she begins to strike, to strike with all her might. At last, the final spasm. Her kidneys give away, piss floods the corpse beneath her. With haggard eyes, she slumps on top of him. (*The Sun*, 118-119).

According to Mutunda (2015: 121), this brutal act by Ateba can be said to be a reaction against male violence as there comes a time when even women, regardless of how docile they are, get tired of the patriarchal order. Some critics have read this murder scene and seen it as an act of retribution on the part of women, and symbolically an act that would avenge women for the yoke of patriarchy they have been saddled with. Mutunda (2015) gives an example of Renée Larrier (2000) who claims that Ateba's act is "her way of revenge in the name of Irene and other women, since their arrival on earth" (Cited in Mutunda, 2015: 86). In the same vein, Augustine Assah (2003, quoted in Mutunda 2015: 86) asserts that "the killing seeks to annihilate man, to make man a non-being. It also seeks to destroy the phallic symbol, source of oppression, violence." In another oeuvre, Mutunda (2016) points out that "this apparent revenge-killing is also meant to debunk masculinist supremacy theory. Beyala shows that women can assert themselves by taking a supreme, if not extreme position that annihilates men's so-called superiority" (2016: 716).

Connell (1987) reminds us that "the authority of men is not spread in an even blanket across every department of social life. In some circumstances women have authority; in others the power of men is diffused, confused or contested" (cited by Mutunda, 2016: 716). In the same vein, Michael Kimmel (2001) argues that "the image of those men who hold power is subject to change or contestation" (2001: 271). This is true for Beyala who, through her protagonist Ateba, has challenged the myth of male supremacy on one hand and female inferiority on the other. Beyala portrays Ateba first as a powerless woman and in the end as a woman with man-like power that enables her to fight back as her way of empowering a gender that is kept subjugated in her society.

It can therefore be said that through this act of violence, Ateba takes revenge for the physical and psychological harm that men have inflicted upon her, her mother and other women. It can be concluded that due to the daily oppression and subjugation that women suffer from men, including sexual abuse and physical violence, they resort to unconventional, violent means to liberate themselves. Ateba's action is reminiscent of Firdaus in El Saadawi's *Woman at Point Zero* (1983). After she suffered so much at the hands of men, Firdaus could not take it anymore; she thus killed her pimp Marzouk in cold blood. She describes the scene as follows:

I caught hold of the latch of the door to open it, but he lifted his arm up in the air and slapped me. I raised my hand even higher than he had done, and brought it down violently on his face. [. . .] His hand started to reach for the knife he carried in his pocket, but my hand was quicker than his. I raised the knife and buried it deep in his neck, pulled it out of his neck and then thrust it deep into his chest, pulled it out of his chest and plunged it deep into his belly. I stuck the knife into almost every part of his body. (*Woman at Point Zero*, 95)

It should be noted that Ateba and Firdaus' reaction to abuses is similar to that of Beatrice in Chimamanda Ngozi's *Purple Hibiscus* (2003) who slowly poisons her husband to death when she gets tired of his abusive nature. After being enslaved by her husband for a long time, Beatrice too decided to break the silence. She ceased to be the traditional good woman and refused to remain silent in the face of tyranny. To borrow Mutunda's (2015) words, this apparent revenge-killing is meant to debunk masculinist supremacy theory. Beyala shows that women can assert themselves by taking a supreme, if not extreme position that defeats men's so called superiority. Mutunda (2015) further quotes Robert Connell (2005), who observes that, "The authority of men is not spread in an even blanket across every department of social life. In some circumstances women have authority; in others the power of men is diffused, confused or contested". Beyala, through her protagonist Ateba, has challenged the myth of male supremacy on one hand and female inferiority on the other (Mutunda, 2015: 121).

This self-defense murder can be seen to be Ateba's ultimate act of resistance and liberation. In the final chapter of the novel, Ateba leaves the room after murdering the man, "Her footsteps reverberate on the asphalt. Slowly she moves on, step by step, towards the radiating brightness on the horizon" (*The Sun*, 119). The young woman loses her grip on reality, she is caught in both the inner spaces of her mind and the outer world of reality. Like Firdaus in *Woman at Point Zero*, Ateba becomes yet another 'madwoman in the attic'. Both women after killing the men do not have any remorse or regrets. In fact they have some sense of satisfaction after getting rid of the aggressor. As Firdaus says after killing the pimp: "I walked down the

street, my head held high to the heavens, with the pride of having destroyed all masks to reveal what is hidden behind” (*Woman at Point Zero*, 96).

The evil that these female characters face at the hands of patriarchy greatly contribute to the perpetuation of such acts. Ateba in *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* for instance becomes tired of surrendering to male sexual violence and the insensitivity of the community in which she lives. By killing the unknown man, she had confronted the oppressor head-on, thereby breaking the silence of women. These acts by the female characters can be seen to be positive as they show the men that women are a force to be reckoned with. These acts also elevate the women from the position of being seen as weak and passive to being assertive and powerful. As Mutunda (2016), states in his oeuvre *Free at Last: A Feminist Insight into Beyala’s The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* and El Saadawi’s *Woman at Point Zero*, “by killing a man, [Ateba] has paved way for women to follow: robust action against men. She is urging women to use force whenever necessary in order to attain liberation from the subjugating patriarchal social structures. In other words, through her protagonist, [Beyala] is urging women to be agents of their own individual destiny” (2016: 720). Although this killing can somewhat be seen as cruel, Beyala seems to encourage it because women’s suffrage is too much in most patriarchal societies. It can be noted that it is when the oppressor is removed from the picture that some women become free. For instance in Adichie’s *Purples Hibiscus* (2003), it is after Papa dies that the family finally has some joy and freedom. It is then that Beatrice and Kambili have their own voice. As the narrator states: “It is one of the few times in the past three years that she has spoken without first being spoken to” (*Purples Hibiscus*, 306).

Beyala also uses language in order to challenge and expose the patriarchal ideals that are practiced in most African societies. She uses the most obscene words in order to bring out the image of how bad the female situation is in the societies in which we live. She uses this language not to hurt or show her lack of decency rather in order to expose the oppressive nature of men. According to Mutunda (2015), “Beyala’s language is a form of protest against the sexual violence repeatedly perpetrated on women” (2015: 87). Mutunda (2015) further quotes Jacques Chevrier (2001) who states that Beyala’s novel is a declaration of war on patriarchal society. In the same vein, he also agrees with Papa Samba Diop (2001) views that Beyala’s writing is “a

missile launched on such targets as polygamy and the minorization of women and children” (Mutunda, 2016: 88).

4.3. Female Gender Empowered

In *Nervous Conditions* (1988), Tsitsi Dangarembga’s literary, focuses on the education of two young women, Tambu and Nyasha - cousins and friends - who try to counter the oppression to which they are subjected. Through her female characters, Dangarembga tries to express that a woman can also stand up for herself. Through Tambu who defies all odds in order to go to school, we learn that girls too can be determined to achieve what they want and succeed in doing so. Tambu because of her desire to go to school and Nhamo’s mockery that she would not achieve her goals grew to hate her brother to the point that even when he passed away, she felt no sadness as expected. The opening remarks in the text reveals her unconcerned attitude to Nhamo’s untimely death: “I was not sorry when my brother died. Nor am I apologising for my callousness, as you may define it, my lack of feeling” (*Nervous Conditions*, 1). One may wonder why Tambu has no remorse for the demise of her brother. As the novel unfold, it becomes clear that it was only because her brother died that she was able to go to school in the first place.

Tambu as a young girl desperate to go to school is set against the backdrop of local traditional opinions and attitudes. Here we are presented with a belief - so typical of many African men - that women count for much less than they do. Near the start of the novel Tambu says: “The needs and sensibilities of the women in my family were not considered a priority or even legitimate” (*Nervous Conditions*, 12). She goes on to tell us of her sense of injustice at the fact that her brother, Nhamo was sent to school so that he, “if given the chance . . . would distinguish himself academically, at least sufficiently to enter a decent profession” (*Nervous Conditions*, 4). Because Nhamo’s education was seen to be a way out of the poverty of the family, the cost of his education was deemed worthwhile. Tambu’s father voices the traditional point of view when he says to his daughter: “Can you cook books and feed them to your husband? Stay at home with your mother. Learn to cook and clean. Grow vegetables” (*Nervous Conditions*, 15). Her mother’s observation that “being a woman was a burden because you had to bear children and look after them and the husband” (16) echoes what is generally held to be the case in most African societies. But for Tambu, this is reason enough to decide that she shall

return to school to complete her education, disrupted because the family's financial precariousness did not allow sending her back to school past Standard Three.

Thus, the eagerness to return to school drove Tambu to grow and sell 'mealies' (maize) to raise the necessary money. Incidentally, she met a generous white lady, Doris, who donated ten pounds towards Tambu's school fees. Her family was not interested in her education and this is why the funds that were sent by Babamukuru were not used for both Tambu and Nhamo's education. This was because of the mind-set of the patriarchal society in which she lived, which promoted male empowerment at the expense of the female child. Tambu however does not give up and this is why she does not even mourn her brother after he dies as she sees that as an opportunity for her to go to school.

Despite the society which she lives in, Tambu is ready to fight so she can go to school and not even her fathers' constant talk and discouragement make her change her mind. Tambu even admires Maiguru who has a degree and wants to be like her. Her concept of becoming a woman was to emulate her aunt, Maiguru. When she was younger, Tambu used to compare the role played by her mother, MaShingayi, and Maiguru, her aunt, in their respective families, and within the clan. Whilst her mother, on the one hand, had to spend the greater part of the day working in the fields to eke out a living, Maiguru on the other hand would be in the classroom teaching. Tambu saw that the definite symbol of empowerment had enabled Maiguru to hold down a decent job and a comfortable home. It was certain that Tambu would fashion her future around her successful aunt at the expense of her mother whom she referred to as "no more than another piece of scenery to be maintained... but all the same superfluous, an obstacle in the part of my departure" (*Nervous Conditions*, 58). Dangaremba through her character shows us that through education a woman can become assertive and exposed. For instance, since Maiguru was educated, she was set above all the other women. Tambu realised that it was because of poverty and lack of education that her parents were able to be pushed around by Babamukuru. Tambu also realised that her mother was not going to get married in "white" when Babamukuru says so if she had been independent therefore, she decided to get educated in order to break free from the cycle of poverty in her family.

Nyasha on the other hand rebels against both Babamukuru's patriarchal control and his collaboration with the colonizer. Although he himself has relinquished in significant ways his Shona traditions, he expects Nyasha to bear the burden of that tradition, particularly through her sexuality because she is a girl. Nyasha however blames her hybrid conditions on her parents who took her and her brother to England, as the following excerpt reveals:

We had forgotten what home was like. I mean really forgotten – what it looked like, what it smelt like, all the things to do and say and not to do and say. It was a real shock! [. . .] We shouldn't have gone, Nyasha was saying, looking disheartened. The parents ought to have packed us off home [. . .] Maybe that would have been best. For them at least, because now they're stuck with hybrids for children. And they don't like it. They don't like it at all. It offends them. They think we do it on purpose, so it offends them. And I don't know what to do about it, Tambu, really I don't. I can't help having been there and grown into me that has been there [. . .]. Really, it's very difficult. (78)

Unlike her father who is trained to collude with the British because he is "cultivable, in the way that land is, to yield harvests that sustain the cultivator" (*Nervous Conditions*, 19). Nyasha refuses to sustain the colonial cultivator, her father and ultimately herself through her illness. She rejects her father's belief that Christian ways are progressive, saying, "it is bad enough when a country gets colonized, but when the people do as well, that is the end, really that's the end" (*Nervous Conditions*, 147). In her text, Dangaremba challenges the colonialist's metaphor of woman as colonized land and exposes the male elite's collaboration in the colonial process. Nyasha who can find no compromise or healthy method of escape effectively transforms her body into a site of rebellion, and in doing so, nearly destroys herself. The short dresses she wears upon her family's return from England and afterwards signifies a kind of threatening sexuality to her father and the community, and even elicits the disapproval of Tambu who describes her cousin as forgetful of her Shona ways. As Tambu prospers through the educational opportunities provided by Babamukuru's wealth, Nyasha becomes entrapped by her father who condemns her to whoredom and insists on his absolute authority over her: "You must learn to be

obedient,' Babamukuru told Nyasha and struck her again. [. . .] 'She has dared to challenge me. Me her father. I am telling you,' and he began to struggle again, 'today she will not live. We cannot have two men in this house, [. . .] your salvation lies in going away from my house' (*Nervous Conditions*, 115). Sympathising with Nyasha, Tambu is of the view that Nyasha is being victimised because she is a woman and can't defend herself: "I [felt] bad for her, thinking how dreadfully familiar that scene had been, with Babamukuru condemning Nyasha to whoredom, making her a victim of her femaleness, just as I felt victimised at home in the days when Nhamo went to school and I grew my maize" (*Nervous Conditions*, 115).

Through her bulimia and anorexia nervosa, a condition with its roots in the denial of sexuality and attempt to gain control of one's body, Nyasha makes Babamukuru her slave because he cannot control what she eats or what she will stomach of his authority. He persistently forces her to eat all her food as an indication of his authority over her and believes that she challenges him if she does not eat even if she is full or not hungry (*Nervous Conditions*, 189). This makes Nyasha equally determined to gobble up the food and then throw it up, a symbol of final defiance of her father's maniacal oppression and she rebels against this ultimate symbol of patriarchal authority (189). Nyasha is keen on challenging her father; she reaches a point where she cannot take his authoritative rule any longer: "He makes me so angry. I can't just shut up when he puts up his God act. I am not just made that way. Why can't I just take it like everybody does?" (*Nervous Conditions*, 190). The cause of her breakdown then can be seen to be a combination of colonization and the father's desire to uphold his African patriarchal tradition, sexist values. At the peak of her rebellion, Nyasha bits between her teeth her English history book calling them 'fucking liars'. She jabs into her flesh the fragments of her clay pots representing her native art. And she tramples the clothes of her wardrobe under foot (*Nervous Conditions*, 201). In this scene she rejects colonial history, she has fragmented her culture and along with the Shona patriarchal traditions which has scarred her flesh, and she refuses her material privileges gained by colonialism capitalist system. Nyasha's attitude here can be compared to that of Firdaus in El Saadawi's *Woman at Point zero* who "tears away the veils" of oppressive social structures. Nyasha attempts to strip away all layers of socialization structures confining her. She refuses to grovel to her father much as Firdaus refuses to be a slave to her pimp. For instance when Babamukuru finds a job for Lucia, Nyasha refuses to join the other

women in adoring him and warns Tambu not to follow suit. She believed that finding Lucia a job was Babamukuru's duty and he needn't to be turned into a hero. She disgustingly states:

Do you see what they have done? They have taken us away. Lucia. Takesure. All of us, they have deprived you of you, him of himself. Ours of each other. We are grovelling. Lucia for a job, Jeremiah for money, daddy grovels to them, we grovel to him [. . .] I won't grovel, I won't die (200).

This fighting back is part of a process of claiming a 'self', part of what Tambu calls the 'painful process of expansion' beyond the borders of gender, race and class hierarchies.

Although Maiguru was Tambu's role model and was obedient and loyal to her husband, her depression one day drove her to rebel against her husband. She had had enough of being subservient to her husband's family. In fact she had the courage to stand up to her husband and say: "I am sick of it Babawa Chido. Let me tell you I have had enough! And when I keep quiet you think I am enjoying it. So today I am telling you I am not happy. I am not happy anymore in this house" (*Nervous Conditions*, 172). Though Maiguru seems a faithful and subservient wife who follows her husband's orders and understood her role as the wife of the head of the clan, she occasionally revolted against this customary order of things. She blatantly stated that: "I am tired of my house being a hotel for your family. I am tired of being a housekeeper for them. I am tired of being nothing in a home that I am working myself sick to support" (*Nervous Conditions*, 72). When Maiguru abandons her beloved family and goes to stay with her brother in Salisbury, this demonstrated how strongly she felt about the issue of being relegated to marginalization when confronted with issues concerning her immediate family. She takes everything in her stride, but when the extended family was involved she tended to see red. She could put up with Nyasha's behaviour but could not tolerate having to serve her in-laws. Maiguru's departure and subsequent return serves as a turning point in the order of power relations in the house. When she comes back to the house, Babamukuru's decisions were no longer unchallengeable. When Babamukuru decided for Tambu that the convent would have a bad influence on her character, it was Maiguru who influenced the decision in favour of attending the Sacred Heart College. Moyana (1996) regards Maiguru as having been "integrated into passively upholding the patriarch's oppressive systems . . . she explodes as the pressure mounts and reaches boiling point" (1996: 31). When

she attempts to leave her husband, it is a sign that she wants to escape his control which actually works to her advantage as Maiguru seems to have gained her husband's respect and is granted a greater say in the decision making of the household, implying that it may be possible to transform the system from within. If women remain docile and digest every ill treatment they gets from the men, it then means that the subjugation will never end. However, if they react to these situations that make them subservient, the men too will begin to respect them.

The women in the novel namely Nyasha, Maiguru, Lucia, Tambu and Ma'Shingayi, deal with patriarchy in various ways throughout the story. Each of these women makes efforts to question the traditions of patriarchy. Although the novel focuses on the story of Tambu and her quest for education and emancipation, it is also concerned on the various struggles that women face and how they get around those problems. For Lucia for example, opposition to patriarchal ideals is more successful because she remains outside the bonds of marriage, the privileges of class, and traditional male control. She argues that she doesn't know how to obey a man because she isn't married (*Nervous Conditions*, 174). She uses her body and her sexuality as a means of achieving freedom and pleasure. When she hooks up with Takesure, she does so of her own volition because her body had appetites of which she was not ashamed (*Nervous Conditions*, 153). Babamukuru comes to respect her and to heed her advice for he applauds her as being "like a man herself" (*Nervous Conditions*, 171), a conclusion he reaches because she is the only woman who controls her body and her livelihood even in the defiance of his authority. Her sexual liberation threatens the patriarchal system of control. What Dangaremba tries to communicate through her is that marriage is not always a woman's destiny. A woman can be able to control her own life and body just like Lucia who only takes sexual pleasure when she pleases. In fact, she retorts that, "A woman has to live with something. Even if it is only a cockroach and cockroaches are better. They are easy to chase away isn't it?" (*Nervous Conditions*, 153). Clearly, Lucia does not need a man to control her life even if she is pregnant by Takesure. It can be noted that she actually stays with him to get sexual satisfaction and knows that she could easily get rid of him. Lucia's thoughts and disregard of men can be seen to be similar to that of Nyasha. When she hands over a tampon to Tambu for her to use, Tambu at first is sceptic as whether to use it or not but Nyasha jokingly tells her that it was better off losing her virginity to a tampon than to a man who would add hers to his hoard of hymens, "They wear them around their waists like scalps she teased." (*Nervous Conditions*, 94).

In the mirror of her characters, Dangaremba elucidates that women too can speak out and question society's philosophies. Lucia for example is an assertive female who does and says what she wants. She disciplines Takesure when he speaks nonsense about her and actually warns Babamukuru that she would leave his house and would take her sister too. She says that Jeremiah is lazy and fails to provide for her sister. As for Takesure, she out rightly states that there is nothing that he can do for her as whatever he could do, she could do better for herself:

You make me sick, the lot of you. [. . .] I shall leave this home of yours, Babamukuru, and I shall take my sister with me. [. . .] But before that, Babamukuru, I want to tell you why I refused to go. It was because of this man, this Jeremiah, yes, you Jeremiah, who married my sister, he has a roving eye and a lazy hand. Whatever he sees, he must have; but he doesn't want to work for it, isn't it, Jeremiah? And why do I bother to tell you? You know it, all of you; you know it. So could I go and leave my sister alone with this man who has given her nothing but misery since the age of fifteen? Of course not. It was not possible. As for Takesure, I don't know what he thinks he can give me. Whatever he can do for me, I can do better for myself. So, Babamukuru don't worry. I'm going. Right now. There's nothing to keep me. But I'm taking my sister with me. (*Nervous Conditions*, 144-145)

Lucia here openly challenges the patriarchs as she tells them that she could do better than some of the men in that household. She also sweet-talks Babamukuru into finding her a job at the Mission (*Nervous Conditions*, 156-159) yet, she frankly tells Babamukuru off for punishing Tambudzai and for forcing her parents into a white wedding without seeking their opinion about it (*Nervous Conditions*, 170-171); and she gives her sister a shock treatment to get her back to health when she degenerates into a psycho-physical invalid (*Nervous Conditions*, 184-186). Generally, then, as Moyana (1994) rightly points out, she asserts her rights without fear of anyone, even the most revered Babamukuru (Moyana, 1994: 35). She uses men to get what she wants in life, including Takesure (whom she calls a 'cockroach') and Babamukuru, and her final triumph is that she enrolls in Grade One in order to fight illiteracy while working at the Mission.

She had not been to school before, and so she felt so proud. As she showed Tambu and Nyasha her books, she states that she could already feel her mind beginning to think more efficiently (*Nervous Conditions*, 60). Even Lucia knew that emancipation could only come through education. According to Moyana Rosemary (1994), Lucia escapes from poverty and male dominance as a result of her being educated. Her future is certain to be bright because she has not been static and perhaps it is significant that she remains unmarried. Moyana further states that the men are not changed or conscientised by her different attitude, with Takesure calling her “vicious and unnatural . . . uncontrollable” (*Nervous Conditions*, 145), and Babamukuru applauding her in her absence saying, “That one, he chuckled to Maiguru, she is like a man herself” (*Nervous Conditions*, 171). It seems to be difficult for these men to acknowledge that Lucia is a person with her own good opinion and style of living her life independently of the fetters that bind other women (Moyana, 1994: 35).

When Tambu goes to the mission school, her growing knowledge and evolving perceptions are a form of emancipation from her old ways of thinking. At first, constant internal dilemmas while trying to make sense of the world that she knew and blindly accepted with the new knowledge she has learnt. These conflicts of interest make Tambu question the African traditions she grew up with, because she realises that these traditions did not serve her or any of the women whom she knew any good. At the end of the text, it can be noted that Tambu is not only emancipated from poverty or restrictions, but also gets her freedom and an assertion of personal liberty. She begins to question things and refuses to be brainwashed and something in her mind began to assert itself.

Before ending this chapter, it is necessary to give a holistic view on the feminist voices in the three selected novels. The female characters in *Nervous Conditions* (Tambu, Nyasha and Lucia), *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* (Ateba), and *One is Enough* (Amaka) liberate themselves from the oppression of the societies they live in. With the aid of education and exposure to their rights and modern trends, these women try to break the stereotype ideals and sexual tendencies that are practiced in their societies. This ascertains the feminist school of thought which believes that women should have the same rights and opportunities as men (Hornby, 2010: 545). This study used all the four types of feminism that were earlier discussed in chapter one in analysing its characters however, distinctive reference is made to African feminism. The women in the

texts under study demand justice and equality with the men and have been courageous and consistent in their pursuit of emancipation. They refuse to conform or adjust their beliefs for the sake of a man's comfort or society's opinion. Even though the writers are from different cultural backgrounds, it can be noted that their female characters have similar problems. They are caught between traditional values and male demands, thus they think the only way to survive is by ending the tyranny of men and patriarchal society. In the *Sun Hath looked Upon Me* for instance, we are confronted with a world of rape and violence. The sexual abuse of women in the text proves the radical feminist's claims that most men have the potential to use physical violence against women, including rape and murder. It is visibly epitomized in the text that Kate Millets (1970) thought that the roots of women's oppressions are buried deep in patriarchy's sex and gender system is spot-on.

However, Ateba uses a militant approach when confronting the male who she sees to be her oppressor. She refuses to be controlled by the patriarchs because of her sexuality. She could be said to have adopted the radical feminist's battlefield of condemning sexual harassment, women battering and sexual coercion. Ateba gets tired of the sexual harassment hence after her friend Irene dies from a botched abortion she decides to confront and eliminate her aggressor. This act by Ateba is linked to what Kate Millet states in her *Sexual Politics* (1970) that since men's control over both the public and private worlds maintains patriarchy; she posits that male control must be eliminated if women are to be liberated. In similar vein, Beyala seems to encourage this and it could be because women's suffrage is too much in most patriarchal societies. It can be noted thus that it is when the oppressor is removed from the picture that some women become free. Mutunda (2016) also lends his voice and opines that, Ateba has set an example for women to follow by killing a man. In Mutunda's words she is urging women to use force whenever necessary in order to attain liberation from the subjugating patriarchal social structures. This act by Ateba is a protest against men's harassment and a way of showing that women can stand up and defend themselves. Like radical feminism, men's aggression towards women and their violent sexuality have been condemned in *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me*.

The patriarchal society in *Nervous Conditions* also demands that a male child's education should be prioritised. However, Tambu is determined to take herself to school and does not give up even when her brother mocks her that she would not amount to anything because she is a girl.

She is tired of being oppressed and hence is determined to be independent so that she does not fall in the traditional roles as set by society. She pitied her mother and did not want to end up like her. What Tambu wanted the most was to be given equal chance and opportunity to prove herself as capable. Akin to the African feminists, the women in *Nervous Conditions* do not intend to be superior over their men, however, they defy the privileged position of men and demand that they too be viewed as individuals. Their desire for freedom, liberty and independence makes them do their best in trying to be heard. Tambu is ready to fight so she can go to school and not even her fathers' constant talk and discouragement makes her change her mind. Lucia also decides to start work and goes back to school. This is exactly what African feminism supports, it does not focus only on comparing male dominance with female subjugation or on fighting battles with men, nor on fertility rates and poverty, but it is about challenging the status quo (Oyewumi 2005, in Atanga, 2008: 308)) and this is the position that Tambu and Lucia in *Nervous conditions* take. They want to recognize their potential beyond their traditional roles and Lucia refuses to be dependent on any man. As Karik-Namiji (2016) in *Feminism and Intra-Gender Relations in Africa* states, Women no longer want to be regarded as weak, inferior or dependent; they want to be accorded some respect. Nyasha on the other hand is rather radical in her approach. This is because she saw patriarchy through the eyes of her father Babamukuru as the sole source of the problems that women used to face in the Sigauke Clan hence her rebellion against him through her anorexia bulimia.

Amaka's break from her marriage to Obiora also symbolises her freedom, opportunities for women, and female solidarity. She stands up for herself and refuses to stay in a marriage where she was constantly humiliated. Amaka breaks away from the barriers of culture and religion by asserting her identity, and freedom in her society. In Lagos, she has a new beginning without limitations but with many expectations. She does this in order for her to live a respectful and honourable life and this is what African feminism encourages. Although African feminism compliments African women's status as mother, it queries compulsory motherhood and the traditional favouring of sons. It respects African women's self-reliance and the penchant to cooperative work and social organization (Davies, 1986: 8-11). This is why Nwapa has created female characters in *One is Enough* who are self-confident and assertive. The "Cash Madams" for instance find it necessary to move to Lagos after the war in order to remain economically independent and do not define themselves solely by marriage and children.

One thing to note in *One is Enough* and *Nervous Conditions* is that the women in these texts are not antagonistic to men and they acknowledge that they need them in their lives as Lucia in *Nervous Conditions* retorts, “A woman has to live with something. Even if it is only a cockroach and cockroaches are better. They are easy to chase away isn’t it?” (*Nervous Conditions*, 153). Through the narrator in *One is Enough*, we also learn that although Amaka did not want to be a wife anymore, She wanted a man; just a man and she wanted to be independent of this man, pure and simple (*One is Enough*, 100). Even children have a place in these women’s lives. African feminism is not anti-male nor motherhood (Chukwuma, 2006; 9) and as Karik (2016: 18) opines African women do not want to assert their superiority over men, however, they want to be given equal chance and opportunity to prove themselves as capable. Ezeigbo (1990: 148) also suggests African woman as a writer does not view the man as indispensable; rather, they view the two sexes as mutually interdependent. As shown in *One is Enough*, after the failure of her marriage, Amaka tells her mother, “No, mother I have said goodbye to husbands,” her mother replied. “That’s better. Goodbye to husbands not goodbye to men. They are two different things” (*One is Enough*, 10). What the women reject is macho control. This is why Amaka decides to separate herself from the chains of marriage. She refuses to be judged by the fact that she could not bear children. She too wanted children nevertheless she refuses to be disgraced for the fact that she could not do so. Mama’s (2001) assertion that African feminist’s struggle for respect, dignity, equality, lives free from violence and the threats of violence is substantiated in this study. This is because the female writers of the texts under study have spoken for the African women and exemplified that they too have a voice.

CHAPTER FIVE: FINDINGS AND CONCLUSION

Female writing emerged out of the need for women to speak up for themselves, to have their voice heard. Their intention was to subvert the patriarchal and social-cultural constructs that reduce the African woman to womanhood and wifehood. The present study has explored the feminist voice in Dangaremba's *Nervous Conditions*, Beyala's *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* and Nwapa's *One is Enough*.

The first objective of this study was to analyse how culture and tradition contributed to the oppression and subjugation of women in the texts that were being investigated. The study reveals that indeed, patriarchal ideals and other traditions contribute to the oppression of women. It was proven during the analysis of the selected texts that most traditions are in favour of and privilege men more than they do to women. It was also established that most cultures have prescribed specific gender roles and this has contributed to the subjugation of women. Traditionally, a woman's place has been inferior to that of her male counterpart. Whatever is considered most valuable in society is placed under the direction of men and whatever is considered less valuable is given to women to care for. As seen in Dangaremba's *Nervous Conditions*, even education is a great concern for women because the Shona people believed that women's education was to be within their sphere. They had placed on their women the mythological role of woman as mother and nurturer. The plight of an African woman as highlighted in the text is that the woman's proper place is assumed to be in the home, serving her family and, later, her husband. The women in the text pay the highest price; all are subjected to the same treatment. Regardless of Maiguru's education, she too had to grovel for her husband.

The bitter truth of the female condition has also been established in Nwapa's *One is enough* in which the state of women in a Nigerian society has been demonstrated. Nwapa in the text has visibly illustrated that the position of a woman in an Igbo society is predictable: she is meant to marry and procreate. Failure to do so brings a lot of fallacies from her people. This can be said to be the reason why there is so much cruelty on Amaka from her husband and her community when she fails to bear a child. The hullabaloo for children as symbols of family posterity, the pride of a woman and the basis of marriages, make the people of Onitsha in Nwapa's *One is Enough* to think of childlessness as evil and the ultimate calamity that can befall any couple. The patriarchal order which mostly favours men however allows the husband to take

up a second wife if his woman cannot bear children. The feelings of the woman are not put into consideration. They are tucked in for no one to see.

Beyala's *The Sun Hath Looked Upon Me* equally shows the views that African society has of women. It can also be perceived from the text that women are victims of patriarchal society's oppression. This oppression – physical as well as emotional – can also be attributed to the fact that most cultures perceive men to be superior and women to be socially and culturally inferior. According to the male-dominated society, women are only meant to serve the needs of men, their superiors.

The second objective was to explore the ways which the women in the texts adopt in order to stop male oppression and how they break the stereotypical and biased ideals practiced in their societies. My analysis reveals that the contemporary female characters are ready to challenge the patriarchal order in their respective societies. Women in the texts form the rational voice(s) that call for change in the way society treats women. Beyala, Dangaremba and Nwapa create assertive characters that are able to speak out for themselves and are able to challenge the biased ideals that are practiced in their societies. The study establishes that women are determined to liberate themselves from the grip of patriarchy even if it means using unconventional and violent means. In the three novels, the authors have encouraged women to talk back to their oppressors so that their condition can be redeemed and eventually improved.

Amaka, in *One is Enough* for example, leaves her marriage when she finds it too humiliating. She breaks away from the barriers of culture and religion by asserting her identity, and freedom. This reaction to the unjust or biased culture of her society depicts Nwapa's view that women should learn to be self-reliant in or outside marriages, whether they have children of their own or not. Amaka's rebellious action demonstrates that Nwapa in her text asserts that women need not suffer social or cultural humiliations, but must stand up to challenge or break off with these inhibitions and choose their own better alternative. Nwapa through her character Amaka brings out the feminist spirit of independence. This action best confirms Chukwuma's (1990) position that, economic independence is a source of female assertion, breaking loose the shackles of subjugation and establishing choice as the basis of interaction (1990: 133).

Similarly, Beyala through her character Ateba challenges patriarchal control over women. In order to set herself free, Ateba commits a brutal act that can be said to be a reaction against male violence as there comes a time when even women, regardless of how docile they are perceived, react to the abusive patriarchal order. She takes revenge for the physical and psychological harm that men have inflicted upon her, her mother and other women. The murder in self-defence can be seen to be Ateba's ultimate act of resistance and liberation. The evil that Ateba suffers at the hands of men makes her kill a man in a rage of fury. This act uplifts the women from the position of being seen as weak and passive to being assertive and powerful. In the same breath, Dangaremba in *Nervous Conditions* creates assertive female characters that are able to speak for themselves. Tambu, for example, was so driven by the desire to educate herself that she sought to sell mealies (maize) in order to pay for her school. She refuses to stay away from school just because her father thought that education of a female child was unimportant. However, she decided to get educated in order to break free from the cycle of poverty in her family and also for her to become independent.

It can therefore be said that, women through their writing have redefined the meaning of feminism. Their main concern has been on issues like gender inequality, sexual exploitation of women, restrictions imposed on women by certain traditions followed in patriarchal societies, and these are the oppressive traditions that they strive to fight. This has been in line with feminist ideology which concerns itself with the emancipation of womenfolk from the oppression of male control.

The last objective of this study was to evaluate how the selected women writers have empowered the female characters in their texts. The study reveals that Nwapa, Beyala and Dangaremba have deliberately intended their protagonists as role models to the women of their respective societies and Africa at large. Nwapa through Amaka demonstrates that women can be happy and fulfilled without children or even marriage. Through Tambudzai, Dangaremba ascertains that female children are as important as male children. Through Ateba, Beyala demonstrates that a woman can fight patriarchy even if it means resorting to using unconventional ways. The women in the selected texts reject patriarchy and the exaltation of maledom. The works of these contemporary female writers give a decisive impetus to women on how they have to manage in order to establish themselves as individuals. This not being an easy

thing considering the gender biases and prejudices in their societies, women have to however soldier ahead and give themselves an identity. The feminist voice in these literary works indicates that useless traditions, gender discrimination and all kinds of harassment should be eliminated from society. African female writers are committed to helping women revive themselves and embrace new identities. Patriarchy can therefore be said to be at the core of most women's problems and so to avoid being enslaved, women should stand up for themselves and fight for their liberation and self-identity.

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